

Essential Grammar

We have learned the basic foundation of the Japanese language. Now that we have a general knowledge of how Japanese works, we can now extend that by learning specific grammar for various situations. This section will go over what is considered to be essential grammar for basic practical Japanese. You will begin to see fewer literal translations in order to emphasize the new grammar now that you (should) have a good understanding of the basic fundamental grammar. For example, in sentences where the subject has not been specified, I might simply specify the subject in the translation as 'he' even though it may very well be "we" or "them" depending on the context.

This section starts with transforming what we have learned so far into a more unassuming and politer form. In any language, there are ways to word things differently to express a feeling of deference or politeness. Even English has differences such as saying, "May I..." vs "Can I...". You may speak one way to your professor and another way to your friends. However, Japanese is different in that not only does the type of vocabulary change, the grammatical structure for *every sentence* changes as well. There is a distinct and clear line differentiating polite and casual types of speech. On the one hand, the rules clearly tell you how to structure your sentences for different social contexts. On the other hand, every sentence you speak must be conjugated to the proper level of politeness. In section 3, we will cover the polite version of Japanese, which is required for speaking to people of higher social position or to people you are unfamiliar with.

This section will then continue to cover the most useful major types of grammar in Japanese. For this reason, we will learn the most common conjugations such as the te-form, potential, conditional, and volitional. The latter sections are in no particular order and neither does it need to be. The grammar that is presented here is essential which means that you have to learn it all anyway and learn them well.

Polite Form and Verb Stems

Not being rude in Japan

Vocabulary

1. 丁寧語 【てい・ねい・ご】 - polite language
2. 尊敬語 【そん・けい・ご】 - honorific language
3. 謙讓語 【けん・じょう・ご】 - humble language
4. はい - yes (polite)
5. いいえ - no (polite)

The Japanese we have learned so far is all well and good if you're 5-years old. Unfortunately, adults are expected to use a politer version of the language (called 丁寧語) when addressing certain people. People you will probably use 丁寧語 with are: 1) people of higher social rank, and 2) people you are not familiar with. Deciding when to use which language is pretty much a matter of "feel". However, it is a good idea to stick with one form for each person.

Later (probably much later), we will learn an even politer version of the language called honorific (尊敬語) and humble (謙讓語) form. It will be more useful than you may think because store clerks, receptionists, and such will speak to you in those forms. But for now, let's concentrate on just 丁寧語, which is the base for 尊敬語 and 謙讓語.

Fortunately, it is not difficult to change casual speech to polite speech. There may be some slight changes to the vocabulary (for example, "yes" and "no" become 「はい」 and 「いいえ」 respectively in polite speech), and very colloquial types of sentence endings are not used in polite speech. (We will learn about sentence endings in a later section.) Essentially, the only main difference between polite and casual speech comes at the very end of the sentence. You cannot even tell whether a person is speaking in polite or casual speech until the sentence is finished.

The stem of verbs

Vocabulary

1. 食べる 【た・ べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
2. 泳ぐ 【およ・ ぐ】 (u-verb) - to swim
3. する (exception) - to do
4. 来る 【く・ る】 (exception) - to come
5. 怒る 【おこ・ る】 (u-verb) - to get angry
6. 鉄拳 【てっ・ けん】 - fist
7. 休み 【やす・ み】 - rest; vacation
8. 飲む 【の・ む】 (u-verb) - to drink
9. 明日 【あした】 - tomorrow
10. 映画 【えい・ が】 - movie
11. 見る 【み・ る】 (ru-verb) - to see
12. 行く 【い・ く】 (u-verb) - to go
13. 友達 【とも・ だち】 - friend
14. 遊ぶ 【あそ・ ぶ】 (u-verb) - to play
15. 楽しむ 【たの・ しむ】 (u-verb) - to enjoy
16. 出す 【だ・ す】 (u-verb) - to bring out
17. 走る 【はし・ る】 (u-verb) - to run
18. 走り出す 【はし・ り・ だ・ す】 (u-verb) - to break into a run
19. 着る 【き・ る】 (ru-verb) - to wear
20. 替える 【か・ える】 (ru-verb) - to switch
21. 着替える 【き・ が・ える】 (ru-verb) - to change (clothes)
22. 付ける 【つ・ ける】 (ru-verb) - to attach
23. 加える 【くわ・ える】 (ru-verb) - to add
24. 付け加える 【つ・ け・ くわ・ える】 (ru-verb) - to add one thing to another
25. 言う 【い・ う】 (u-verb) - to say
26. 言い出す 【い・ い・ だ・ す】 (u-verb) - to start talking

In order to conjugate all u-verbs and ru-verbs into their respective polite forms, we will first learn about the stem of verbs. This is often called the *masu-stem* in Japanese textbooks but we will call it just the *stem* because it is used in many more conjugations than just its masu-form. The stem is really great because it's very easy to produce and is useful in many different types of grammar.

Rules for extracting the stem of verbs

- **For ru-verbs:** Remove the 「る」
Example: 食べる → 食べ
- **For u-verbs:** The last vowel sound changes from an / u / vowel sound to an / i / vowel sound.
Example: 泳ぐ → 泳ぎ

- **Exceptions:**

1. 「**する**」 becomes 「**し**」
2. 「**くる**」 becomes 「**き**」

The stem when used by itself can be a very specialized and limited way of creating nouns from verbs. While the 「**の**」 particle allows you to talk about verbs as if they were nouns, the stem actually turns verbs into nouns. In fact, in very rare cases, the stem is used more often than the verb itself. For example, the stem of 「怒る」 (**いかる**) is used more often than the verb itself. The movie, "Fists of Fury" is translated as 「怒りの鉄拳」 and not 「怒る鉄拳」. In fact, 「怒る」 will most likely be read as 「おこる」, a completely different verb with the same meaning and kanji! There are a number of specific nouns (such as 「休み」) that are really verb stems that are used like regular nouns. However, in general we cannot take any verb and make it into a noun. For example, the following sentence is wrong.

- ~~飲みをする。~~

(This sentence makes sense but no one talks like this)

However, a useful grammar that works in general for stems of all verbs is using the stem as a target with a motion verb (almost always 「行く」 and 「来る」 in this case). This grammar means, "to go or to come to do [some verb]". Here's an example.

1. 明日、映画を**見**に行く。 - Tomorrow, go to see movie.

「**見**に」 is the stem of 「見る」 (which is **見**) combined with the target particle 「**に**」.

The motion target particle 「**へ**」 sounds like you're literally going or coming to something while the 「**に**」 particle implies that you are going or coming for the purpose of doing something.

1. 昨日、友達が**遊び**へきた。

Yesterday, friend came to a playing activity. (Sounds a bit strange)

2. 昨日、友達が**遊び**にきた。

Yesterday, friend came to play.

The expression 「楽しみにする」 meaning "to look forward to" is formed from grammar similar to this but is a special case and should be considered a set expression.

Other verbs are also sometimes attached to the stem to create new verbs. For example, when 「出**す**」 is attached to the stem of 「走る」, which is 「**走り**」, you get 「**走り出**す」 meaning "to break out into a run". Other examples include 「切り**替**える」, which means "to switch over to something else", and 「付け**加**える」, which means "to add something by attaching it". You can see how the separate meanings of the two verbs are combined to create the new combined verb. For example, 「**言**い**出**す」 means "to start talking", combining the meaning, "to speak" and "to bring out". There are no general rules here, you need to just memorize these combined verbs as separate

verbs in their own right.

Things that are written in a formal context such as newspaper articles also use the stem as a conjunctive verb. We will come back to this later in the formal expression lesson.

Using 「～ます」 to make verbs polite

Vocabulary

1. 明日 【あした】 - tomorrow
2. 大学 【だい・がく】 - college
3. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
4. 先週 【せん・しゅう】 - last week
5. 会う 【あ・う】 (u-verb) - to meet
6. 晩ご飯 【ばん・ご・はん】 - dinner
7. 食べる 【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
8. 面白い 【おも・しろ・い】 (i-adj) - interesting
9. 映画 【えい・が】 - movie
10. 見る 【み・る】 (ru-verb) - to see

Of course, the reason I introduced the verb stem is to learn how to conjugate verbs into their polite form... the masu-form! The masu-form must always come at the end of a complete sentence and never inside a modifying relative clause. When we learn compound sentences, we will see that each sub-sentence of the compound sentence can end in masu-form as well.

To conjugate verbs into the masu-form, you attach different conjugations of 「ます」 to the stem depending on the tense. Here is a chart.

A conjugation chart with sample stem 「遊び」

	ます conjugations	Stem+ます
Plain	ます	遊び <u>ます</u>
Negative	ません	遊び <u>ません</u>
Past	ました	遊び <u>ました</u>
Past-Neg	ませんでした	遊び <u>ませんでした</u>

Examples

1. 明日、大学に行きます。
Tomorrow, go to college.
2. 先週、ボブに会いましたよ。
You know, met Bob last week.
3. 晩ご飯を食べませんでしたね。
Didn't eat dinner, huh?
4. 面白くない映画は見ません。
About not interesting movies, do not see (them).

Using 「です」 for everything else

Vocabulary

1. かわいい (i-adj) - cute
2. 静か 【しず・か】 (na-adj) - quiet
3. 子犬 【こ・いぬ】 - puppy
4. とても - very
5. 好き 【す・き】 (na-adj) - likable; desirable
6. 昨日 【きのう】 - yesterday
7. 時間 【じ・かん】 - time
8. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
9. その - that (abbr of 「そのの」)
10. 部屋 【へ・や】 - room
11. 先週 【せん・しゅう】 - last week
12. 見る 【み・る】 (ru-verb) - to see
13. 映画 【えい・が】 - movie
14. 面白い 【おも・しろ・い】 (i-adj) - interesting

For any sentence that does not end in a ru-verb or u-verb, the only thing that needs to be done is to add 「です」 or 「でした」. You can also do this for substituted nouns (both 「の」 and 「ん」) by just treating them like regular nouns. Another important thing to remember is that if there is a declarative 「だ」, it must be removed. In being polite, I guess you can't be so bold as to forwardly declare things the way 「だ」 does. Just like the masu-form, this must also go at the end of a complete sentence. Here is a chart illustrating the conjugations.

i-adjective (だ cannot be used)

	Casual	Polite
Plain	かわいい	かわいい <u>です</u>
Negative	かわいくない	かわいくない <u>です</u>
Past	かわいかった	かわいかった <u>です</u>
Past-Neg	かわいくなかった	かわいくなかった <u>です</u>

na-adjective/noun (might have to remove だ)

	Casual	Polite
Plain	静か (だ)	静か <u>です</u>
Negative	静かじゃない	静かじゃない <u>です</u>
Past	静かだった	！静か <u>でした</u>
Past-Neg	静かじゃなかった	静かじゃなかった <u>です</u>

！ Notice in the case of noun/na-adjective only, the past tense becomes 「でした」. A very common mistake is to do the same for i-adjectives. Remember 「かわいいでした」 is wrong!

Examples

- 1. 子犬はとても好きです。
About puppies, like very much. (The most natural translation is that someone likes puppies very much but there is not enough context to rule out that the puppies like something very much.)
- 2. 昨日、時間がなかったんです。
It was that there was no time yesterday.
- 3. その部屋はあまり静かじゃないです。
That room is not very quiet.
- 4. 先週に見た映画は、とても面白かったです。
Movie saw last week was very interesting.

Reality Check

I have heard on a number of occasions that the negative non-past conjugation as given here is not an "officially" correct conjugation. Instead what's considered to be a more "correct" conjugation is to actually replace the 「ないです」 part with 「ありません」. The reasoning is that the polite negative form of the verb 「ある」 is not 「ないです」 but 「ありません」. Therefore, 「かわいくない」 actually becomes 「かわいくありません」 and 「静かじゃない」 becomes 「静かじゃありません」.

The reality of today's Japanese is that what's supposed to be the "official" conjugation sounds rather stiff and formal. In normal everyday conversations, the conjugation presented here will be used almost every time. While you should use the more formal conjugations for written works using the polite form, you'll rarely hear it in actual speech. In conclusion, I recommend studying and becoming familiar with both types of conjugations.

A more formal negative conjugation

	Casual	Polite
Negative	かわいくない	かわいく <u>ありません</u>
Past-Neg	かわいくなかった	かわいく <u>ありませんでした</u>
Negative	静かじゃない	静かじゃ <u>ありません</u>
Past-Neg	静かじゃなかった	静かじゃ <u>ありませんでした</u>

Examples

- 1. その部屋はあまり静かじゃないですよ。
You know, that room is not very quiet.
- 2. その部屋はあまり静かじゃありませんよ。
You know, that room is not very quiet.

「です」 is NOT the same as 「だ」

Vocabulary

1. そう - so
2. 思う 【おも・う】 (u-verb) - to think
3. はい - yes (polite)
4. 答える 【こた・える】 (ru-verb) - to answer

Many of you who have taken Japanese classes have probably been taught that 「です」 is the polite version of 「だ」. However, I want to point some several key differences here and the reasons why they are in fact completely different things. It is impossible to fully explain the reasons why they are fundamentally different without discussing grammar that have yet to be covered so I would like to target this toward those who have already started learning Japanese and have been incorrectly misinformed that 「だ」 is the casual version of 「です」. For the rest of you new to this, you can easily skip this part.

I'm sure most of you have learned the expression 「そう」 by now. Now, there are four ways to make a complete sentence using the state-of-being with 「そう」 to produce a sentence that says, "That is so."

Different ways to say, "That is so."

1. そう。
2. そうだ。
3. そうです。
4. そうでございます。

The first 「そう」 is the implied state-of-being and 「そうだ」 is the declarative. As I've stated before, the non-assuming soft spoken 「そう」 is often used by females while the more confident 「そうだ」 is often used by males.

「そうです」 is the polite version of 「そう」, created by attaching 「です」 to the noun. 「そうです」 is **not** the polite version of 「そうだ」 where the 「だ」 is replaced by 「です」 and I'll explain why.

Perhaps we wanted to make that sentence into a question instead to ask, "Is that so?" There are several ways to do this but some possibilities are given in the following. (This grammar is covered in a later section.)

Different ways to ask, "Is that so?"

1. そう？
2. そうか？
3. そうですか？

As I've explained before, the 「だ」 is used to declare what one believes to be a fact. Therefore, 「そうだか？」 is not a valid way to ask a question because it is declaring a fact and asking a question at the same time. But the fact that 「そうですか」 is a valid question shows that 「です」 and 「だ」 are essentially different. 「そうです」, in showing respect and humbleness, is not as assertive and is merely the polite version of 「そう」.

Besides the difference in nuance between 「だ」 and 「です」, another key difference is that 「だ」 is used in many different types of grammar to delineate a relative clause. 「です」, on the other hand, is only used at the end of a sentence to designate a polite state-of-being. For instance, consider the two following sentences. (This grammar is covered in a later section.)

- そうだと思います
I think that is so.
- そうですと思います
(Incorrect sentence)

「そうだと思います」 is valid while 「そうですと思います」 is not because 「です」 can only go at the end of the sentence. 「です」 can only be in a relative clause when it is a direct quote of what someone said such as the following.

- 「はい、そうです」と答えた。

In conclusion, replacing 「です」 with 「だ」, thinking one is the polite equivalent of the other or vice-versa will potentially result in grammatically incorrect sentences. It is best to think of them as totally separate things (because they are).

Addressing People

Not only is it important to use the right type of language with the right people, it is also important to address them by the right name. It is also important to address yourself with the proper level of politeness. Japanese is special in that there are so many ways of saying the simple words, "I" and "you". We will go over some of ways to refer to yourself and others.

Referring to yourself

Vocabulary

- 名前 【な・ まえ】 - name

There are many ways to say "I" in Japanese. Some of these words are not as common and others are hopelessly outdated. We will go over the most common ones that are in use today. The usages of all the different words for "I" is separated into two categories: gender and politeness. In other words, there are words that are usually used by males and words that are usually only used by females and they all depend on the social context.

Before going into this: a note about the word 「私」. The official reading of the kanji is 「わたくし」. This is the reading you is used in a formal context (for example, a speech by the president of a company). This reading will probably be accompanied with honorific and humble forms, which we will cover later. In all other situations, it is usually read as 「わたし」. This is the most generic reference to "I" in terms of politeness and gender; therefore it is usually one of the first words taught to students of Japanese.

Here is a list of the most common words for "I" and how they are used:

1. 私 【わたくし】 - Used by both males and females for formal situations.
2. 私 【わたし】 - Used by both males and females for normal polite situations.
3. 僕 【ぼく】 - Used primarily by males from fairly polite to fairly casual situations.
4. 俺 【おれ】 - A very rough version of "I" used almost exclusively by males in very casual situations.
5. あたし - A very feminine and casual way to refer to oneself. Many girls have decided to opt for 「わたし」 instead because 「あたし」 has a cutesy and girly sound.
6. One's own name - Also a very feminine and kind of childish way to refer to oneself.
7. わし - Usually used by older men well in their middle-ages.

Let's see how different types of sentences use the appropriate version of "I". 「わたくし」 is left out because we have yet to go over very formal grammatical expressions.

1. 私の名前はキムです。
My name is Kim. (Neutral, polite)
2. 僕の名前はキムです。
My name is Kim. (Masculine, polite)
3. 僕の名前はボブだ。
My name is Bob. (Masculine, casual)
4. 俺の名前はボブだ。
My name is Bob. (Masculine, casual)
5. あたしの名前はアリス。
My name is Alice. (Feminine, casual)

Referring to others by name

Vocabulary

1. 社長【しゃ・ちょう】 - company president
2. 課長【か・ちょう】 - section manager
3. 先生【せん・せい】 - teacher
4. 田中【た・なか】 - Tanaka (last name)

Japanese does not require the use of "you" nearly as much as English does. I hope that the examples with Bob, Alice, and Jim have shown that people refer to other people by their names even when they are directly addressing that person. Another common way to address people is by their title such as 「社長」、「課長」、「先生」, etc. The word 「先生」 is used to generally mean any person who has significant knowledge and expertise in something. For example, people usually use 「先生」 when directly addressing doctors or teachers (obviously). You can also include the person's last name such as 「田中先生」 (teacher Tanaka). In the case where your relationship with the person doesn't involve any title, you can use their name (usually their last name) attached with 「さん」 to show politeness. If calling them by their last name seems a little too polite and distant, the practice of attaching 「さん」 to their first name also exists. More endearing and colloquial versions of 「さん」 include 「くん」 and 「ちゃん」. 「くん」 is usually attached to the name of males who are of equal or lower social position. (For example, my boss sometimes calls me 「キムくん」). 「ちゃん」 is a very endearing way to refer to usually females of equal or lower social position.

Referring to others with "you"

Please do not use 「あなた」 just like you would use the word "you" in English. In directly addressing people, there are three levels of politeness: 1) Using the person's name with the appropriate suffix, 2) Not using anything at all, 3) Using 「あなた」. In fact, by the time you get to three, you're dangerously in the area of being rude. Most of the time, you do not need to use anything at all because you are directly addressing the person. Constantly pounding the listener with "you" every sentence sounds like you are accusing the person of something.

「あなた」 is also an old-fashioned way for women to refer to their husband or lover. Unless you are a middle-aged women with a Japanese husband, I doubt you will be using 「あなた」 in this fashion as well.

Here is a list of some words meaning "you" in English. You will rarely need to use any of these words, especially the ones in the second half of the list.

1. あなた - Generally only used when there is no way to physically address the person or know the person's name. For example, direct questions to the reader on a form that the reader must fill out would use 「あなた」.
2. 君【きみ】 - Can be a very close and assuming way to address girls (especially by guys). Can also be kind of rude.
3. お前【お・まえ】 - A very rough and coarse way to address someone. Usually used by guys and often changed to 「おめえ」.
4. あんた - A very assuming and familiar way to address someone. The person using this is maybe miffed off about something.
5. 手前【て・めえ】 - Very rude. Like 「お前」, to add extra punch, people will usually say it like, 「てめ～～」. Sounds like you want to beat someone up. I've only seen this one used in movies and comic books. In fact, if you try this on your friends, they will probably laugh at you and tell you that you've probably been reading too many comic books.
6. 貴様【き・さま】 - Very, very rude. Sounds like you want to take someone out. I've also only seen this one used in comic books. I only go over it so you can understand and enjoy comic books yourself!

Referring to others in third person

Vocabulary

1. 彼 【かれ】 - he; boyfriend
2. 彼女 【かの・じょ】 - she; girlfriend
3. ガールフレンド - girlfriend
4. ボーイフレンド - boyfriend

You can use 「彼」 and 「彼女」 for "he" and "she" respectively. Notice that 「彼」 and 「彼女」 can also mean "boyfriend" and "girlfriend". So how can you tell which meaning is being used? Context, of course. For example, if someone asks, 「彼女ですか？」 the person is obviously asking if she is your girlfriend because the question, "Is she she?" doesn't make any sense. Another less commonly used alternative is to say 「ガールフレンド」 and 「ボーイフレンド」 for, well, I'm sure you can guess what they mean.

Referring to family members

- 1. 母【はは】 - mother
- 2. お母さん【お・ かあ・ さん】 - mother (polite)
- 3. 両親【りょう・ しん】 - parents
- 4. 父【ちち】 - father
- 5. お父さん【お・ とう・ さん】 - father (polite)
- 6. 妻【つま】 - wife
- 7. 奥さん【おく・ さん】 - wife (polite)
- 8. 夫【おっと】 - husband
- 9. 主人【しゅ・ じん】 - husband
- 10. 姉【あね】 - older sister
- 11. お姉さん【お・ ねえ・ さん】 - older sister (polite)
- 12. 兄【あに】 - older brother
- 13. お兄さん【お・ にい・ さん】 - older brother (polite)
- 14. 妹【いもうと】 - younger sister
- 15. 弟【おとうと】 - younger brother
- 16. 息子【むす・ こ】 - son
- 17. 娘【むすめ】 - daughter

Referring to family members is a little more complicated than English. (It could be worse, try learning Korean!) For the purpose of brevity, (since this *is* a grammar guide and not a vocabulary guide) we will only go over the immediate family. In Japanese, you refer to members of other people's family more politely than your own. This is only when you are talking about members of your own family to others outside the family. For example, you would refer to your own mother as 「母」 to people outside your family but you might very well call her 「お母さん」 at home within your own family. There is also a distinction between older and younger siblings. The following chart list some of the most common terms for family members. There may also be other possibilities not covered in this chart.

Family member chart

	One's own family	Someone else's family
Parents	両親	ご両親
Mother	母	お母さん
Father	父	お父さん
Wife	妻	奥さん
Husband	夫	ご主人
Older Sister	姉	お姉さん
Older Brother	兄	お兄さん
Younger Sister	妹	妹さん
Younger Brother	弟	弟さん
Son	息子	息子さん

Daughter	娘	娘さん
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Another word for wife, 「家内」 is often considered politically incorrect because the kanji used are "house" and "inside" which implies that wives belong in the home. Amen. (Just kidding)

The Question Marker

Questions in polite form

Vocabulary

1. 田中 【た・ なか】 - Tanaka (last name)
2. お母さん 【お・ かあ・ さん】 - mother (polite)
3. どこ - where
4. 鈴木 【すず・ き】 - Suzuki (last name)
5. 母 【はは】 - mother
6. 買い物 【か・ い・ もの】 - shopping
7. 行く 【い・ く】 (u-verb) - to go
8. イタリア - Italy
9. 料理 【りょう・ り】 - cooking; cuisine; dish
10. 食べる 【た・ べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
11. すみません - sorry (polite)
12. ちょっと - a little
13. お腹 【お・ なか】 - stomach
14. いっぱい - full
15. ごめんなさい - sorry (polite)
16. ごめん - sorry

The question marker is covered here because it is primarily used to clearly indicate a question in polite sentences. While it is entirely possible to express a question even in polite form using just intonation, the question marker is often attached to the very end of the sentence to indicate a question. The question marker is simply the hiragana character 「か」 and you don't need to add a question mark. For previously explained reasons, you must not use the declarative 「だ」 with the question marker.

Example 1

田中さん：お母さんはどこですか。

Tanaka-san: Where is (your) mother?

鈴木さん：母は買い物に行きました。

Suzuki-san: (My) mother went shopping.

Example 2

キムさん：イタリア料理を食べに行きませんか。

Kim-san: Go to eat Italian food?

鈴木さん：すみません。ちょっと、お腹がいっぱいです。

Suzuki-san: Sorry. (My) stomach is a little full.

Here the question is actually being used as an invitation just like how in English we say, "Won't you come in for a drink?" 「すみません」 is a polite way of apologizing. Slightly less formal is 「ごめんなさい」 while the casual version is simply 「ごめん」.

The question marker in casual speech

Vocabulary

1. こんな - this sort of
2. 本当【ほん・とう】 - real
3. 食べる【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
4. そんな - that sort of
5. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)

It makes sense to conclude that the question marker would work in exactly the same way in casual speech as it does in polite speech. However, this is **not** the case. The question marker 「か」 is usually not used with casual speech to make actual questions. It is often used to consider whether something is true or not. Depending on the context and intonation, it can also be used to make rhetorical questions or to express sarcasm. It can sound quite rough so you might want to be careful about using 「か」 for questions in the plain casual form.

Examples

1. こんなのを本当に食べる **か** ?
Do you think [he/she] will really eat this type of thing?
2. そんなのは、ある **か** よ !
Do I look like I would have something like that?!

Instead of 「か」, real questions in casual speech are usually asked with the explanatory の particle or nothing at all except for a rise in intonation, as we have already seen in previous sections.

1. こんなのを本当に食べる ?
Are you really going to eat something like this?
2. そんなのは、ある **の** ?
Do you have something like that?

「か」 used in relative clauses

Vocabulary

1. 昨日【きのう】 - yesterday
2. 何【なに】 - what
3. 食べる【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
4. 忘れる【わす・れる】 (ru-verb) - to forget
5. 彼【かれ】 - he; boyfriend
6. 言う【い・う】 (u-verb) - to say
7. 分かる【わ・かる】 (u-verb) - to understand
8. 先生【せん・せい】 - teacher
9. 学校【がっ・こう】 - school
10. 行く【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
11. 教える【おし・える】 (ru-verb) - to teach; to inform
12. どう - how
13. 知る【し・る】 (u-verb) - to know

Another use of the question marker is simply grammatical and has nothing to do with the politeness. A question marker attached to the end of a relative clause makes a mini-question inside a larger sentence. This allows the speaker to talk about the question. For example, you can talk about the question, "What did I eat today?" In the following examples, the question that is being considered is in red.

1. 昨日何を食べたか忘れた。
Forgot what I ate yesterday.
2. 彼は何を言ったか分からない。
Don't understand what he said.
3. 先生が学校に行ったか教えない？
Won't you inform me whether teacher went to school?

In sentences like example 3 where the question being considered has a yes/no answer, it is common (but not necessary) to attach 「どうか」. This is roughly equivalent to saying, "whether or not" in English. You can also include the alternative as well to mean the same thing.

1. 先生が学校に行ったかどうか知らない。
Don't know whether or not teacher went to school.
2. 先生が学校に行ったか行かなかったか知らない。
Don't know whether teacher went to school or didn't.

Using question words

Vocabulary

- 1. おいしい (i-adj) - tasty
- 2. クッキー - cookie
- 3. 全部 【ぜん・ぶ】 - everything
- 4. 食べる 【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
- 5. 誰 【だれ】 - who
- 6. 盗む 【ぬす・む】 (u-verb) - to steal
- 7. 知る 【し・る】 (u-verb) - to know
- 8. 犯人 【はん・にん】 - criminal
- 9. 見る 【み・る】 (ru-verb) - to see
- 10. この - this (abbr. of これの)
- 11. 中 【なか】 - inside
- 12. ～から (particle) - from ～
- 13. 選ぶ 【えら・ぶ】 (u-verb) - to select

While we're on the topic of questions, this is a good time to go over question words (where, who, what, etc.) and what they mean in various contexts. Take a look at what adding the question marker does to the meaning of the words.

Question Words

Word+Question Marker	Meaning
誰か	Someone
何か	Something
いつか	Sometime
どこか	Somewhere
どれか	A certain one from many

Examples

As you can see by the following examples, you can treat these words just like any regular nouns.

- 1. 誰かがおいしいクッキーを全部食べた。
Someone ate all the delicious cookies.
- 2. 誰が盗んだのか、誰か知りませんか。
Doesn't anybody know who stole it?
- 3. 犯人をどこかで見ましたか。
Did you see the criminal somewhere?
- 4. この中からどれかを選ぶの。
(Explaining) You are to select a certain one from inside this (selection).

Question words with inclusive meaning

Vocabulary

- 1. 全部【ぜん・ぶ】 - everything
- 2. 皆【みんな】 - everybody
- 3. 皆さん【みな・さん】 - everybody (polite)
- 4. この - this (abbr. of これの)
- 5. 質問【しつ・もん】 - question
- 6. 答え【こた・え】 - answer
- 7. 知る【し・る】 (u-verb) - to know
- 8. 友達【とも・だち】 - friend
- 9. 遅れる【おく・れる】 (ru-verb) - to be late
- 10. ここ - here
- 11. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
- 12. レストラン - restaurant
- 13. おいしい (i-adj) - tasty
- 14. 今週末【こん・しゅう・まつ】 - this weekend
- 15. 行く【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go

The same question words in the chart above can be combined with 「も」 in a negative sentence to mean "nobody" (誰も), "nothing" (何も), "nowhere" (どこも), etc.

「誰も」 and 「何も」 are primarily used only for negative sentences. Curiously, there is no way to say "everything" with question words. Instead, it is conventional to use other words like 「全部」. And although 「誰も」 can sometimes be used to mean "everybody", it is customary to use 「皆」 or 「皆さん」

The remaining three words 「いつも」 (meaning "always") and 「どれも」 (meaning "any and all"), and 「どこも」 (meaning everywhere) can be used in both negative and positive sentences.

Inclusive Words	
Word+も	Meaning
誰も	Everybody/Nobody
何も	Nothing (negative only)
いつも	Always
どこも	Everywhere
どれも	Any and all

Examples

- 1. この質問の答えは、誰も知らない。
Nobody knows the answer of this question.

2. 友達はいつも遅れる。
Friend is always late.
3. ここにあるレストランはどれもおいしくない。
Any and all restaurants that are here are not tasty.
4. 今週末は、どこにも行かなかった。
Went nowhere this weekend.

(Grammatically, this 「も」 is the same as the topic particle 「も」 so the target particle 「に」 must go before the topic particle 「も」 in ordering.)

Question words to mean "any"

Vocabulary

1. この - this (abbr. of これの)
2. 質問 【しつ・もん】 - question
3. 答え 【こた・え】 - answer
4. 分かる 【わ・かる】 (u-verb) - to understand
5. 昼ご飯 【ひる・ご・はん】 - lunch
6. いい (i-adj) - good
7. あの - that (over there) (abbr. of あれの)
8. 人 【ひと】 - person
9. 本当 【ほん・とう】 - real
10. 食べる 【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat

The same question words combined with 「でも」 can be used to mean "any". One thing to be careful about is that 「何でも」 is read as 「なんでも」 and *not* 「なにでも」

Words for "Any"

Word+でも	Meaning
誰 <u>でも</u>	Anybody
何 <u>でも</u>	Anything
いつ <u>でも</u>	Anytime
どこ <u>でも</u>	Anywhere
どれ <u>でも</u>	Whichever

Examples

1. この質問の答えは、誰でも分かる。
Anybody understands the answer of this question.
2. 昼ご飯は、どこでもいいです。
About lunch, anywhere is good.
3. あの人は、本当に何でも食べる。

That person really eats anything.

Compound Sentences

In this section, we will learn various ways to combine multiple simple sentences into one complex sentence. For example, we will learn how to chain separate sentences together to express multiple actions or states. In other words, if we have two simple sentences with the same subject, "I ran" and "I ate", we will learn how to group them together to mean, "I ran and ate." We will also learn how to do this with adjectives and nouns. (Ex: He is rich, handsome, and charming.)

Expressing a sequence of states

Vocabulary

1. 一般的 【いっ・ばん・てき】 - in general
2. 静か 【しず・か】 (na-adj) - quiet
3. 狭い 【せま・い】 (i-adj) - narrow
4. 彼女 【かの・じょ】 - she; girlfriend
5. いい (i-adj) - good
6. 私 【わたし】 - me; myself; I
7. 部屋 【へ・や】 - room
8. きれい (na-adj) - pretty; clean
9. とても - very
10. 好き 【す・き】 (na-adj) - likable; desirable
11. 学生 【がく・せい】 - student
12. 先生 【せん・せい】 - teacher
13. 田中 【た・なか】 - Tanaka (last name)
14. お金持ち 【お・かね・も・ち】 - rich
15. カッコいい (i-adj) - cool; handsome
16. 魅力的 【み・りょく・てき】 - charming

It is very easy to combine a chain of nouns and adjectives to describe a person or object. For example, in English if we wanted to say, "He is X. He is Y. He is Z." since all three sentences have the same noun, we would usually say, "He is X, Y, and Z." In Japanese, we can do the same thing by conjugating the noun or adjective. The last noun or adjective remains the same as before.

How to chain nouns and adjectives together

- **For nouns and na-adjectives:** Attach 「で」 to the noun or na-adjective.

Examples

1. 一般的 → 一般的で
2. 静か → 静かで

- **For i-adjectives and negative noun/adjectives:** Replace the 「い」 with 「くて」 .
!For 「いい」 and 「カッコいい」, the 「い→よ」 exception applies here as well.

Examples

1. 狭い → 狭くて
2. 彼女じゃない → 彼女じゃなくて
3. いい → よくて

Examples

1. 私の部屋は、きれいで、静かで、とても好き。
My room is clean, quiet, and I like it a lot.
2. 彼女は、学生じゃなくて、先生だ。
She is not a student, she is a teacher.
3. 田中さんは、お金持ちで、かっこよくて、魅力的ですね。
Tanaka-san is rich, handsome, and charming, isn't he?

As you can see, the 「で」 attached to 「お金持ち」 obviously cannot be the context particle 「で」 here because there is no verb. It might be helpful to think of 「で」 as merely a substitution for 「だ」 that can be chained together.

Expressing a sequence of verbs with the te-form

Vocabulary

1. 学生 【がく・せい】 - student
2. 買う 【か・う】 (u-verb) - to buy
3. 食べる 【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
4. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
5. する (exception) - to do
6. 遊ぶ 【あそ・ぶ】 (u-verb) - to play
7. 飲む 【の・む】 (u-verb) - to drink
8. 食堂 【しょく・どう】 - cafeteria
9. 昼ご飯 【ひる・ご・はん】 - lunch
10. 昼寝 【ひる・ね】 - afternoon nap
11. 時間 【じ・かん】 - time
12. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
13. 映画 【えい・が】 - movie
14. 見る 【み・る】 (ru-verb) - to see

In a similar fashion, you can express multiple actions. It is usually interpreted as a sequence of event. (I did [X], then I did [Y], then I finally did [Z].) There are two forms: positive and negative. The tense of all the actions is determined by the tense of the last verb.

How to chain verbs together

- **Positive:** Conjugate the verb to its past tense and replace 「た」 with 「て」 or 「だ」 with 「で」. This is often called the *te-form* even though it could sometimes be 'de'.
- **Negative:** Same as i-adjectives, replace 「い」 with 「くて」. This rule also works for the polite 「です」 and 「ます」 endings.

Examples

1. 学生です → 学生でした → 学生でして
2. 買います → 買いました → 買いまして

Sample conjugations

Past Tense	Te-form
食べ <u>た</u>	食べ <u>て</u>
行っ <u>た</u>	行っ <u>て</u>
し <u>た</u>	し <u>て</u>
遊ん <u>だ</u>	遊ん <u>で</u>

Negative	Te-form
食べな <u>い</u>	食べな <u>くて</u>
行か <u>ない</u>	行か <u>なくて</u>
しな <u>い</u>	しな <u>くて</u>
遊ばな <u>い</u>	遊ばな <u>くて</u>

飲んだ

飲んで

飲まない

飲まなくて

Examples

1. 食堂に行って、昼ご飯を食べて、昼寝をする。
I will go to cafeteria, eat lunch, and take a nap.
2. 食堂に行って、昼ご飯を食べて、昼寝をした。
I went to cafeteria, ate lunch, and took a nap.
3. 時間がありまして、映画を見ました。
There was time and I watched a movie.

Expressing reason or causation using 「から」 and 「ので」

Vocabulary

1. 時間【じ・かん】 - time
2. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
3. パーティー - party
4. 行く【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
5. 友達【とも・だち】 - friend
6. プレゼント - present
7. 来る【く・る】 (exception) - to come
8. 田中【た・なか】 - Tanaka (last name)
9. どうして - why
10. 山田【や・まだ】 - Yamada (last name)
11. 一郎【いち・ろう】 - Ichirou (first name)
12. 直子【なお・こ】 - Naoko (first name)
13. ちょっと - a little
14. 忙しい【いそが・しい】 (i-adj) - busy
15. そろそろ - gradually; soon
16. 失礼【しつ・れい】 - discourtesy
17. する (exception) - to do
18. 学生【がく・せい】 - student
19. お金【お・かね】 - money
20. ここ - here
21. 静か【しず・か】 (na-adj) - quiet
22. とても - very
23. 穏やか【おだ・やか】 (na-adj) - calm, peaceful
24. 会う【あ・う】 (u-verb) - to meet

You can connect two complete sentences using 「から」 to indicate a reason for something. The two sentences are always ordered [reason] から [result]. When the reason is a non-conjugated noun or na-adjective, you **must** add 「だ」 to explicitly declare the reason in the form of 「(noun/na-adjective) **だ** から」. If you forget to add the declarative 「だ」 to 「から」, it will end up sounding like the 「から」 meaning "from" which was first introduced in the section on particles, earlier.

Examples

1. 時間がなかった**から**パーティーに行きませんでした。
There was no time so didn't go to party.
2. 友達**から**プレゼントが来た。
Present came **from** friend.
3. 友達**だから**プレゼントが来た。
Present came **because** (the person is) friend. (This sentence sounds a bit odd.)

Either the reason or the result can be omitted if it is clear from the context. In the case of polite

speech, you would treat 「から」 just like a regular noun and add 「です」.

Example 1

田中さん： どうしてパーティーに行きませんでしたか。

Tanaka-san: Why didn't you go to the party?

山田さん： 時間がなかったからです。

Yamada-san: It's because I didn't have time.

Example 2

一郎： パーティーに行かなかったの？

Ichiro: You didn't go to the party?

直子： うん、時間がなかったから。

Naoko: Yeah, because I didn't have time.

Example 3

When you omit the reason, you must include the declarative 「だ」 or 「です」.

直子： 時間がなかった。

Naoko: I didn't have time.

一郎： だから パーティーに行かなかったの？

Ichiro: Is that why you didn't go to the party?

Notice that we could have also used the explanatory 「の」 to express the same thing. In other words, 山田さん could have also said, 「時間がなかったのです」 or 「時間がなかったんです」 while 直子 could have said 「時間がなかったの」 (we'll assume she wants to use the more feminine form). In fact, this is where 「ので」 possibly came from. Let's say you want to combine two sentences: 「時間がなかったのだ」 and 「パーティーに行かなかった」. Remember we can treat the 「の」 just like a noun so we can use what we just learned in the first section of this lesson.

時間がなかったのだ + パーティーに行かなかった

becomes:

時間がなかったのでパーティーに行かなかった。

In fact, 「ので」 is almost interchangeable with 「から」 with a few subtle differences. 「から」 explicitly states that the sentence preceding is the reason for something while 「ので」 is merely putting two sentences together, the first with an explanatory tone. This is something I call causation where [X] happened, therefore [Y] happened. This is slightly different from 「から」 where [Y] happened explicitly *because* [X] happened. This difference tends to make 「ので」 sound softer and slightly more polite and it is favored over 「から」 when explaining a reason for doing something

that is considered discourteous.

- ちょっと忙しい**ので**、そろそろ失礼します。

Because I'm a little busy, I'll be making my leave soon.

(「失礼します」, which literally means "I'm doing a discourtesy", is commonly used as a polite way to make your leave or disturb someone's time.)

Reminder: Don't forget that the explanatory 「の」 requires a 「な」 for both non-conjugated nouns and na-adjectives. Review Particles 3 to see why.

1. 私は学生**な**ので、お金がないんです。

Because I'm a student, I have no money (lit: there is no money).

2. ここは静か**な**ので、とても穏やかです。

It is very calm here because it is quiet.

3. **な**ので、友達に会う時間がない。

That's why there's no time to meet friend.

Just like how the explanatory 「の」 can be shortened to 「ん」, in speech, the 「ので」 can be changed to 「んで」 simply because it's easier to slur the sounds together rather than pronouncing the / o / syllable.

1. 時間がなかった**んで**パーティーに行かなかった。

Didn't go to the party because there was no time.

2. ここは静かな**んで**、とても穏やかです。

It is very calm here because it is quiet.

3. **なんで**、友達に会う時間がない。

That's why there's no time to meet friend.

Using 「のに」 to mean "despite"

Vocabulary

1. 毎日 【まい・ にち】 - everyday
2. 運動 【うん・ どう】 - exercise
3. する (exception) - to do
4. 全然 【ぜん・ ぜん】 - not at all (when used with negative)
5. 痩せる 【や・ せる】 (ru-verb) - to become thin
6. 学生 【がく・ せい】 - student
7. 彼女 【かの・ じょ】 - she; girlfriend
8. 勉強 【べん・ きょう】 - study

Grammatically, 「のに」 is used exactly the same way as 「ので」. When used to combine two simple sentences together, it means "[Sentence 1] despite the fact that [Sentence 2]." However the order is reversed: [Sentence 2]のに[Sentence 1].

Examples

1. 毎日運動したのに、全然痩せなかった。
Despite exercising every day, I didn't get thinner.
2. 学生なのに、彼女は勉強しない。
Despite being a student, she does not study.

Expressing contradiction using 「が」 and 「けど」

Vocabulary

1. デパート - department store
2. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
3. 何 【なに / なん】 - what
4. 全然 【ぜん・ぜん】 - not at all (when used with negative)
5. 欲しい 【ほ・しい】 (i-adj) - desirable
6. 友達 【とも・だち】 - friend
7. 聞く 【き・く】 (u-verb) - to ask; to listen
8. 知る 【し・る】 (u-verb) - to know
9. 今日 【きょう】 - today
10. 暇 【ひま】 - free (as in not busy)
11. 明日 【あした】 - tomorrow
12. 忙しい 【いそが・しい】 (i-adj) - busy
13. 彼 【かれ】 - he; boyfriend
14. まだ - yet
15. 好き 【す・き】 (na-adj) - likable; desirable
16. いい (i-adj) - good
17. 物 【もの】 - object
18. たくさん - a lot (amount)
19. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
20. 見る 【み・る】 (ru-verb) - to see
21. 面白い 【おも・しろ・い】 (i-adj) - interesting

Used in the same manner as 「から」 and 「ので」, 「が」 and 「けど」 also connect two sentences together but this time to express a contradiction. Just like 「から」 the declarative 「だ」 is required for nouns and na-adjectives. And just like 「から」 and 「ので」, either part of the contradiction can be left out.

Examples

1. デパートに行きましたが、何も欲しくなかったです。
I went to department store but there was nothing I wanted.
2. 友達に聞いたけど、知らなかった。
I asked (or heard from) a friend but he (or I) didn't know.
3. 今日は暇だけど、明日は忙しい。
I'm free today but I will be busy tomorrow.
4. だけど、彼がまだ好きなの。
That may be so, but it is that I still like him. [explanation, feminine tone]

It may seem odd but 「聞く」 can either mean "to listen" or "to ask". You may think this may become confusing but the meaning is usually clear within context. In the second example, we're assuming that the friend didn't know, so the speaker was probably asking the friend. Yet again we see the

importance of context in Japanese because this sentence can also mean, "I heard from a friend but I didn't know" since there is neither subject nor topic.

Similar to the difference between 「から」 and 「ので」, 「が」 has a softer tone and is slightly more polite than 「けど」. Though this isn't a rule as such, it is generally common to see 「が」 attached to a 「～ます」 or 「～です」 ending and 「けど」 attached to a regular, plain ending. A more formal version of 「けど」 is 「けれども」 and even more formal is 「けれども」, which we may see later when we cover formal expressions.

Unlike the English word for contradiction such as "but" or "however", 「けど」 and 「が」 do not always express a direct contradiction. Often times, especially when introducing a new topic, it is used as a general connector of two separate sentences. For example, in the following sentences, there is no actual contradiction but 「が」 and 「けど」 are used simply to connect the sentences. Sometimes, the English "and" becomes a closer translation than "but".

1. デパートに行きましたが、いい物がたくさんありました。
I went to the department store and there was a lot of good stuff.
2. マトリックスを見たけど、面白かった。
I watched the "Matrix" and it was interesting.

Expressing multiple reasons using 「し」

Vocabulary

1. どうして - why
2. 友達【とも・だち】 - friend
3. 先生【せん・せい】 - teacher
4. 年上【とし・うえ】 - older
5. 彼【かれ】 - he; boyfriend
6. 好き【す・き】 (na-adj) - likable
7. 優しい【やさ・しい】 (i-adj) - gentle; kind
8. かっこいい (i-adj) - cool; handsome
9. 面白い【おも・し・ろい】 (i-adj) - interesting

When you want to list reasons for multiple states or actions you can do so by adding 「し」 to the end of each relative clause. It is very similar to the 「や」 particle except that it lists reasons for verbs and state-of-being. Again, for states of being, 「だ」 must be used to explicitly declare the state-of-being for any non-conjugated noun or na-adjective. Let's look at some examples.

Example 1

A : どうして友達じゃないんですか？

A: Why isn't (he/she) friend [seeking explanation]?

B : 先生だし、年上だし・・・。

B: Well, he's/she's the teacher, and older...

Example 2

A : どうして彼が好きなの？

A: Why (do you) like him?

B : 優しいし、かっこいいし、面白いから。

B: Because he's kind, attractive, and interesting (among other things).

Notice that 「優しくて、かっこよくて、面白いから。」 could also have worked but much like the difference between the 「と」 and 「や」 particle, 「し」 implies that there may be other reasons.

Expressing multiple actions or states using 「～たりする」

Vocabulary

1. する (exception) - to do
2. 食べる 【た・ べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
3. 飲む 【の・ む】 (u-verb) - to drink
4. 簡単 【かん・ たん】 (na-adj) - simple
5. 難しい 【むずか・ しい】 (i-adj) - difficult
6. 映画 【えい・ が】 - movie
7. 見る 【み・ る】 (ru-verb) - to see
8. 本 【ほん】 - book
9. 読む 【よ・ む】 (u-verb) - to read
10. 昼寝 【ひる・ ね】 - afternoon nap
11. この - this (abbr. of これの)
12. 大学 【だい・ がく】 - college
13. 授業 【じゅ・ ぎょう】 - class

This is the verb version of the 「や」 particle. You can make an example list of verbs among a possible larger list by conjugating each verb into the past tense and adding 「り」. At the end, you need to attach the verb 「する」. Just like the 「や」 particle, the tense is determined by the last verb, which in this case will always be 「する」 (since you have to attach it at the end).

You can also use this with the state-of-being to say that you are a number of things at various random times among a larger list. Similar to regular verbs, you just take the noun or adjective for each state-of-being and conjugate it to the past state-of-being and then attach 「り」. Then finally, attach 「する」 at the end.

Rules for stating a list of verbs among a larger list using 「～たりする」

- **For verbs:** Conjugate each verb to the past tense and add 「り」. Finally, add 「する」 at the very end.

Example

食べるる、飲むむ → 食べたた、飲んだんだ → 食べたたり、飲んだたり → 食べたり、飲んだり する

- **For state-of-being:** Conjugate the noun or adjective for each state-of-being to the past tense and add 「り」. Finally, add 「する」 at the very end.

Example

簡単、難しい → 簡単だった、難しかった → 簡単だったり、難しかったり → 簡単だったり、難しかったり する

1. 映画を見たり、本を読んだり、昼寝したりする。
I do things like (among other things) watch movies, read books, and take naps.
2. この大学の授業は簡単だったり、難しかったりする。
Class of this college is sometimes easy, sometimes difficult (and other times something else maybe).

As you can see, the tense and negative/positive state is controlled by the last 「する」.

1. 映画を見たり、本を読んだりした。
I did things like (among other things) watch movies, and read books.
2. 映画を見たり、本を読んだりしない。
I don't do things like (among other things) watch movies, and read books.
3. 映画を見たり、本を読んだりしなかった。
I didn't do things like (among other things) watch movies, and read books.

Other uses of the te-form

The te-form is incredibly useful as it is used widely in many different types of grammatical expressions. We will learn about enduring states with the 「～ている」 and 「～である」 form. Even though we have learned various conjugations for verbs, they have all been one-time actions. We will now go over how one would say, for example, "I am running." We will also learn how to perform an action for the future using the 「～ておく」 expression and to express directions of actions using 「～ていく」 and 「～てくる」.

Using 「～ている」 for enduring states

Vocabulary

- 1. 食べる【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
- 2. 読む【よ・む】 (u-verb) - to read
- 3. 友達【とも・だち】 - friend
- 4. 何【なに】 - what
- 5. する (exception) - to do
- 6. 昼ご飯【ひる・ご・はん】 - lunch
- 7. 教科書【きょう・か・しょ】 - textbook
- 8. 話【はなし】 - story
- 9. 聞く【き・く】 (u-verb) - to ask; to listen
- 10. ううん - casual word for "no" (nah, uh-uh)

We already know how to express a state-of-being using 「です」, 「だ」, etc. However, it only indicates a one-time thing; you are something or not. This grammar, however, describes a continuing state of an action verb. This usually translates to the progressive form in English except for a few exceptions, which we will examine later. We can make good use of the te-form we learned in the last section because the only thing left to do is add 「いる」! You can then treat the result as a regular ru-verb.

This 「いる」 is the same ru-verb describing existence, first described in the negative verb section. However, in this case, you don't have to worry about whether the subject is animate or inanimate.

Using 「～ている」 for enduring states

To describe a continuing action, first conjugate the verb to the te-form and then attach the verb 「いる」. The entire result conjugates as a ru-verb.

Examples

- 1. 食べる → 食べて → 食べている
- 2. 読む → 読んで → 読んでいる

The result conjugates as a ru-verb regardless of what the original verb is

	Positive		Negative	
Non-Past	読んで <u>いる</u>	reading	読んで <u>いない</u>	is not reading
Past	読んで <u>いた</u>	was reading	読んで <u>いなかった</u>	was not reading

Example 1

A : 友達は何をしているの？

A: What is friend doing?

B : 昼ご飯を食べている。

B: (Friend) is eating lunch.

Note that once you've changed it into a regular ru-verb, you can do all the normal conjugations. The examples below show the masu-form and plain negative conjugations.

Example 2

A : 何を読んでいる？

A: What are you reading?

B : 教科書を読んでいます。

B: I am reading textbook.

Example 3

A : 話を聞いていますか。

A: Are you listening to me? (lit: Are you listening to story?)

B : ううん、聞いていない。

B: No, I'm not listening.

Since people are usually too lazy to roll their tongues to properly pronounce the 「い」, it is often omitted in conversational Japanese. If you are writing an essay or paper, you should always include the 「い」. Here are the abbreviated versions of the previous examples.

Example 4

A : 友達は何をしてるの？

A: What is friend doing?

B : 昼ご飯を食べてる。

B: (Friend) is eating lunch.

Example 5

A : 何を読んでる？

A: What are you reading?

B : 教科書を読んでいます。

B: I am reading textbook.

Example 6

A : 話を聞いていますか。

A: Are you listening to me? (lit: Are you listening to story?)

B : ううん、聞いてない。

B: No, I'm not listening.

Notice how I left the 「い」 alone for the polite forms. Though people certainly omit the 「い」 even in polite form, you might want to get used to the proper way of saying things first before getting carried away with casual abbreviations. You will be amazed at the extensive types of abbreviations that exist in casual speech. (You may also be amazed at how long everything gets in super polite speech.) Basically, you will get the abbreviations if you just act lazy and slur everything together. Particles also get punted off left and right.

For example:

1. 何をしているの? (Those particles are such a pain to say all the time...)
2. 何しているの? (Ugh, I hate having to spell out all the vowels.)
3. 何してんの? (Ah, perfect.)

Enduring state-of-being vs enduring state of action

Vocabulary

1. 知る 【し・ る】 (u-verb) - to know
2. 分かる 【わ・ かる】 (u-verb) - to understand
3. 今日 【きょう】 - today
4. この - this (abbr. of これの)
5. 歌 【うた】 - song
6. 道 【みち】 - road
7. はい - yes (polite)

There are certain cases where an enduring state doesn't translate into the progressive form. In fact, there is an ambiguity in whether one is in a state of *doing* an action versus being in a state that *resulted* from some action. This is usually decided by context and common practices. For example, although 「結婚している」 can technically mean someone is in a chapel currently getting married, it is usually used to refer to someone who is already married and is currently in that married state. We'll now discuss some common verbs that often cause this type of confusion for learners of Japanese.

「知る」

「知る」 means "to know". English is weird in that "know" is supposed to be a verb but is actually describing a state of having knowledge. Japanese is more consistent and 「知る」 is just a regular action verb. In other words, I "knew" (action) something and so now I know it (state). That's why the English word "to know" is really a continuing state in Japanese, namely: 「知っている」.

「知る」 vs 「分かる」

「分かる」 meaning "to understand" may seem similar to 「知る」 in some cases. However, there is a difference between "knowing" and "understanding". Try not to confuse 「知っている」 with 「分かっている」. 「分かっている」 means that you are already in a state of understanding, in other words, you already get it. If you misuse this, you may sound pompous. ("Yeah, yeah, I got it already.") On the other hand, 「知っている」 simply means you know something.

Examples

1. 今日、知りました。
I found out about it today. (I did the action of knowing today.)
2. この歌を知っていますか？
Do (you) know this song?
3. 道は分かりますか。
Do you know the way? (lit: Do (you) understand the road?)
4. はい、はい、分かった、分かった。

Yes, yes, I got it, I got it.

Motion Verbs (行く、来る、etc.)

Vocabulary

1. 鈴木 【すず・き】 - Suzuki (last name)
2. どこ - where
3. もう - already
4. 家 【1) うち; 2) いえ】 - 1) one's own home; 2) house
5. 帰る 【かえ・る】 (u-verb) - to go home
6. 先 【さき】 - before
7. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
8. 美恵 【み・え】 - Mie (first name)
9. 来る 【く・る】 (exception) - to come

It is reasonable to assume the actions 「行っている」 and 「来ている」 would mean, "going" and "coming" respectively. But unfortunately, this is not the case. The 「～ている」 form of motion verbs is more like a sequence of actions we saw in the last section. You completed the motion, and now you exist in that state. (Remember, 「いる」 is the verb of existence of animate objects.) It might help to think of it as two separate and successive actions: 「行って」、and then 「いる」.

Examples

1. 鈴木さんはどこですか。
Where is Suzuki-san?
2. もう、家に帰っている。
He is already at home (went home and is there now).
3. 先に行っているよ。
I'll go on ahead. (I'll go and be there before you.)
4. 美恵ちゃんは、もう来ているよ。
Mie-chan is already here, you know. (She came and is here.)

Using 「～である」 for resultant states

Vocabulary

1. 準備【じゅん・び】 - preparations
2. どう - how
3. もう - already
4. する (exception) - to do
5. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
6. 旅行【りょ・こう】 - travel
7. 計画【けい・かく】 - plans
8. 終わる【お・わる】 (u-verb) - to end
9. うん - casual word for "yes" (yeah, uh-huh)
10. 切符【きつ・ぷ】 - ticket
11. 買う【か・う】 (u-verb) - to buy
12. ホテル - hotel
13. 予約【よ・やく】 - reservation

Appropriately enough, just like there is an 「ある」 to go with 「いる」, there is a 「～である」 form that also has a special meaning. By replacing 「いる」 with 「ある」, instead of a continuing action, it becomes a resultant state after the action has already taken place. Usually, this expression is used to explain that something is in a state of completion. The completed action also carries a nuance of being completed in preparation for something else.

Since this grammar describes the state of a completed action, it is common to see the 「は」 and 「も」 particles instead of the 「を」 particle.

Example 1

A : 準備はどうですか。

A: How are the preparations?

B : 準備は、もうしてあるよ。

B: The preparations are already done.

Example 2

A : 旅行の計画は終わった？

A: Are the plans for the trip complete?

B : うん、切符を買ったし、ホテルの予約もしてある。

B: Uh huh, not only did I buy the ticket, I also took care of the hotel reservations.

Using the 「～ておく」 form as preparation for the future

Vocabulary

1. 晩ご飯【ばん・ご・はん】 - dinner
2. 作る【つく・る】 (u-verb) - to make
3. 電池【でん・ち】 - battery
4. 買う【か・う】 (u-verb) - to buy

While 「～てある」 carries a nuance of a completed action in preparation for something else, 「～ておく」 explicitly states that the action is done (or will be done) with the future in mind. Imagine this: you have made a delicious pie and you're going to *place* it on the window sill for it to cool so that you can eat it later. This image might help explain why the verb 「おく」 (置く), meaning "to place", can be used to describe a preparation for the future. (It's just too bad that pies on window sills always seem to go through some kind of mishap especially in cartoons.) While 「置く」 by itself is written in kanji, it is customary to use hiragana when it comes attached to a conjugated verb (such as the te-form).

Examples

1. 晩ご飯を作っておく。
Make dinner (in advance for the future).
2. 電池を買っておきます。
I'll buy batteries (in advance for the future).

「ておく」 is also sometimes abbreviated to 「～とく」 for convenience.

1. 晩ご飯を作っとく。
Make dinner (in advance for the future).
2. 電池を買っときます。
I'll buy batteries (in advance for the future).

Using motion verbs (行く、来る) with the te-form

Vocabulary

1. えんぴつ - pencil
2. 持つ 【も・つ】 (u-verb) - to hold
3. いる (ru-verb) - to exist (animate)
4. 学校 【がっ・こう】 - school
5. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
6. 家 【1) うち; 2) いえ】 - 1) one's own home; 2) house
7. 来る 【く・る】 (exception) - to come
8. お父さん 【お・とう・さん】 - father (polite)
9. 早い 【はや・い】 (i-adj) - fast; early
10. 帰る 【かえ・る】 (u-verb) - to go home
11. 駅 【えき】 - station
12. 方 【ほう】 - direction, way
13. 走る 【はし・る】 (u-verb) - to run
14. 冬 【ふゆ】 - winter
15. 入る 【はい・る】 (u-verb) - to enter
16. コート - coat
17. 着る 【き・る】 (ru-verb) - to wear
18. 増える 【ふ・える】 (ru-verb) - to increase
19. 一生懸命 【いっ・しょう・けん・めい】 - with all one's might
20. 頑張る 【がん・ば・る】 (u-verb) - to try one's best
21. 色々 【いろ・いろ】 (na-adj) - various
22. 人 【ひと】 - person
23. 付き合う 【つ・き・あ・う】 (u-verb) - to go out with; to keep in company with
24. いい (i-adj) - good
25. まだ - yet
26. 見つかる 【み・つかる】 (u-verb) - to be found
27. 日本語 【に・ほん・ご】 - Japanese (language)
28. ずっと - long; far
29. 前 【まえ】 - front; before
30. 勉強 【べん・きょう】 - study
31. する (exception) - to do
32. 結局 【けっ・きょく】 - eventually
33. やめる (ru-verb) - to stop; to quit

You can also use the motion verbs "to go" (行く) and "to come" (来る) with the te-form, to show that an action is oriented toward or from someplace. The most common and useful example of this is the verb 「持つ」 (to hold). While 「持っている」 means you are in a state of holding something (in possession of), when the 「いる」 is replaced with 「いく」 or 「くる」, it means you are taking or bringing something. Of course, the conjugation is the same as the regular 「行く」 and 「来る」.

Examples

1. えんぴつを持っている？
Do (you) have a pencil?
2. 鉛筆を学校へ持っていく？
Are (you) taking pencil to school?
3. 鉛筆を家に持ってくる？
Are (you) bringing pencil to home?

For these examples, it may make more sense to think of them as a sequence of actions: hold and go, or hold and come. Here are a couple more examples.

1. お父さんは、早く帰ってきました。
Father came back home early.
2. 駅の方へ走っていった。
Went running toward the direction of station.

The motion verbs can also be used in time expressions to move forward or come up to the present.

1. 冬に入って、コートを着ている人が増えていきます。
Entering winter, people wearing coat will increase (toward the future).
2. 一生懸命、頑張っていく！
Will try my hardest (toward the future) with all my might!
3. 色々な人と付き合ってきたけど、いい人はまだ見つからない。
Went out (up to the present) with various types of people but a good person hasn't been found yet.
4. 日本語をずっと前から勉強してきて、結局はやめた。
Studied Japanese from way back before and eventually quit.

Potential Form

Expressing the ability to do something

In Japanese, the ability to do a certain action is expressed by conjugating the verb rather than adding a word such as the words "can" or "able to" in the case of English. All verbs conjugated into the potential form become a ru-verb.

The Potential Form

Vocabulary

1. 見る 【み・る】 (ru-verb) - to see
2. 遊ぶ 【あそ・ぶ】 (u-verb) - to play
3. する (exception) - to do
4. 来る 【く・る】 (exception) - to come
5. 出来る 【で・き・る】 (ru-verb) - to be able to do
6. 食べる 【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
7. 着る 【き・る】 (ru-verb) - to wear
8. 信じる 【しん・じる】 (ru-verb) - to believe
9. 寝る 【ね・る】 (ru-verb) - to sleep
10. 起きる 【お・きる】 (ru-verb) - to wake; to occur
11. 出る 【で・る】 (ru-verb) - to come out
12. 掛ける 【か・ける】 (ru-verb) - to hang
13. 調べる 【しら・べる】 (ru-verb) - to investigate
14. 話す 【はな・す】 (u-verb) - to speak
15. 書く 【か・く】 (u-verb) - to write
16. 待つ 【ま・つ】 (u-verb) - to wait
17. 飲む 【の・む】 (u-verb) - to drink
18. 取る 【と・る】 (u-verb) - to take
19. 死ぬ 【し・ぬ】 (u-verb) - to die
20. 買う 【か・う】 (u-verb) - to buy
21. 漢字 【かん・じ】 - Kanji
22. 残念 【ざん・ねん】 (na-adj) - unfortunate
23. 今週末 【こん・しゅう・まつ】 - this weekend
24. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
25. もう - already

Once again, the conjugation rules can be split into three major groups: ru-verbs, u-verbs, and exception verbs. However, the potential form of the verb 「する」 (meaning "to do") is a special exception because it becomes a completely different verb: 「できる」 (出来る)

Rules for creating potential form

- **For ru-verbs:** Replace the 「る」 with 「られる」.
Example: 見る → 見られる
- **For u-verbs:** Change the last character from a / u / vowel sound to the equivalent / e / vowel sound and add 「る」.
Example: 遊ぶ → 遊べ → 遊べる
- **Exceptions:**
 1. 「する」 becomes 「できる」

2. 「くる」 becomes 「こられる」

Remember that all potential verbs become ru-verbs.

Sample ru-verbs

Plain	Potential
食べる	食べられる
着る	着られる
信じる	信じられる
寝る	寝られる
起きる	起きられる
出る	出られる
掛ける	掛けられる
調べる	調べられる

Sample u-verbs

Plain	Potential
話す	話せる
書く	書ける
遊ぶ	遊べる
待つ	待てる
飲む	飲める
取る	取れる
死ぬ	死ねる
買う	買える

Exception Verbs

Plain	Potential
する	できる
くる	こられる

It is also possible to just add 「れる」 instead of the full 「られる」 for ru-verbs. For example, 「食べる」 becomes 「食べれる」 instead of 「食べられる」. I suggest learning the official 「られる」 conjugation first because laziness can be a hard habit to break and the shorter version, though common, is considered to be slang.

Examples

1. 漢字は書けますか？

Can you write kanji?

2. 残念だが、今週末は行けない。

It's unfortunate, but can't go this weekend.

3. もう信じられない。

I can't believe it already.

Potential forms do not have direct objects

Vocabulary

1. 富士山 【ふ・じ・さん】 - Mt. Fuji
2. 登る 【のぼ・る】 (u-verb) - to climb
3. 重い 【おも・い】 (i-adj) - heavy
4. 荷物 【に・もつ】 - baggage
5. 持つ 【も・つ】 (u-verb) - to hold

The potential form indicates that something is possible but no actual action is actually taken. While the potential form is still a verb, because it is describing the state of feasibility, in general, you don't want to use the direct object 「を」 as you would with the non-potential form of the verb. For example the following sentences sound unnatural.

1. 富士山 を 登れた。
2. 重い荷物 を 持てます。

Here are the versions using either 「が」 or 「は」 instead:

1. 富士山 が 登れた。
Was able to climb Fuji-san.
2. 重い荷物 は 持てます。
Am able to hold heavy baggage.

Are 「見える」 and 「聞こえる」 exceptions?

Vocabulary

1. 見える 【み・える】 (ru-verb) - to be visible
2. 聞こえる 【き・こえる】 (ru-verb) - to be audible
3. 今日 【きょう】 - today
4. 晴れる 【は・れる】 (ru-verb) - to be sunny
5. 富士山 【ふ・じ・さん】 - Mt. Fuji
6. 友達 【とも・だち】 - friend
7. おかげ - thanks to
8. 映画 【えい・が】 - movie
9. ただ - free of charge; only
10. 見る 【み・る】 (ru-verb) - to see
11. こと - event, matter
12. 出来る 【で・き・る】 (ru-verb) - to be able to do
13. 久しぶり 【ひさ・しぶり】 - after a long time
14. 彼 【かれ】 - he; boyfriend
15. 声 【こえ】 - voice
16. 聞く 【き・く】 (u-verb) - to ask; to listen
17. 周り 【まわ・り】 - surroundings
18. うるさい (i-adj) - noisy
19. 言う 【い・う】 (u-verb) - to say
20. あまり / あんまり - not very (when used with negative)

There are two verbs 「見える」 and 「聞こえる」 that mean that something is visible and audible, respectively. When you want to say that you can see or hear something, you'll want to use these verbs. If however, you wanted to say that you were given the opportunity to see or hear something, you would use the regular potential form. However, in this case, it is more common to use the type of expression as seen in example 3.

Examples

1. 今日は晴れて、富士山が見える。
(It) cleared up today and Fuji-san is visible.
2. 友達のおかげで、映画はただで見られた。
Thanks to (my) friend, (I) was able to watch the movie for free.
3. 友達のおかげで、映画をただで見ることができた。
Thanks to (my) friend, (I) was able to watch the movie for free.

You can see that example 3 uses the generic noun for an event to say literally, "The event of seeing movie was able to be done." which essentially means the same thing as 「見られる」. You can also just use generic noun substitution to substitute for 「こと」.

1. 友達のおかげで、映画をただで見るのができた。

Here's some more examples using 「聞く」, can you tell the difference? Notice that 「聞こえる」 always means "audible" and never "able to ask".

1. 久しぶりに彼の声が聞けた。

I was able to hear his voice for the first time in a long time.

2. 周りがうるさくて、彼が言っていることがあんまり聞こえなかった。

The surroundings were noisy and I couldn't hear what he was saying very well.

「ある」, yet another exception

Vocabulary

1. そんな - that sort of
2. こと - event, matter
3. 有り得る【あ・り・え・る / あ・り・う・る】 (ru-verb) - to possibly exist
4. 彼【かれ】 - he; boyfriend
5. 寝坊【ね・ぼう】 - oversleep
6. する (exception) - to do
7. それ - that
8. 話【はなし】 - story

You can say that something has a possibility of existing by combining 「ある」 and the verb 「得る」 to produce 「あり得る」. This essentially means 「あることができる」 except that nobody actually says that, they just use 「あり得る」. This verb is very curious in that it can be read as either 「ありうる」 or 「ありえる」, *however*; all the other conjugations such as 「ありえない」、「ありえた」、and 「ありえなかった」 only have one possible reading using 「え」.

Examples

1. そんなことはありうる。
That kind of situation/event is possible (lit: can exist).
2. そんなことはありえる。
That kind of situation/event is possible (lit: can exist).
3. そんなことはありえない。
That kind of situation/event is not possible (lit: cannot exist).
4. 彼が寝坊したこともありうるね。
It's also possible that he overslept. (lit: The event that he overslept also possibly exists.)
5. それは、ありえない話だよ。
That's an impossible story/scenario. (lit: That story/scenario cannot exist.)

Using する and なる with the に particle

We can use the verbs 「する」 and 「なる」 in conjunction with the 「に」 particle to make various useful expressions. We are used to using the object particle with 「する」 because something is usually done to something else. We will see how the meaning changes when we change the particle to 「に」. As for 「なる」, it is always used with the 「に」 particle because "becoming" is not an action done to something else but rather a target of change. The only grammatical point of interest here is using 「なる」 with i-adjectives and verbs.

Using 「なる」 and 「する」 for nouns and na-adjectives

Vocabulary

1. 彼【かれ】 - he; boyfriend
2. 日本語【に・ほん・ご】 - Japanese (language)
3. 上手【じょう・ず】 (na-adj) - skillful
4. なる (u-verb) - to become
5. 私【わたし】 - me, myself, I
6. 医者【い・しゃ】 - doctor
7. 有名【ゆう・めい】 (na-adj) - famous
8. 人【ひと】 - person
9. ハンバーガー - hamburger
10. サラダ - salad
11. する (exception) - to do
12. 他【ほか】 - other
13. いい (i-adj) - good
14. 物【もの】 - object
15. たくさん - a lot (amount)
16. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
17. やはり / やっぱり - as I thought
18. これ - this

As already explained, using 「なる」 with nouns and na-adjectives presents nothing new and acts pretty much the way you'd expect.

1. 彼の日本語が上手になった。
His Japanese has become skillful.
2. 私は医者になった。
I became a doctor.
3. 私は有名な人になる。
I will become a famous person.

For adjectives, using the verb 「する」 with the 「に」 particle is just a review back to the lesson on adverbs. However, for nouns, when you use the verb 「する」 with the 「に」 particle, it means that you are going to do things toward something. This changes the meaning of 「する」 to mean, "to decide on [X]". This is a common expression to use, for instance, when you are ordering items on a menu.

1. 私は、ハンバーガーとサラダにします。
I'll have the hamburger and salad. (lit: I'll do toward hamburger and salad.)
2. 他にいいものがたくさんあるけど、やっぱりこれにする。
There are a lot of other good things, but as I thought, I'll go with this one.

If you think this expression is strange, think about the English expression, "I'll go with the hamburger."

Exactly where are you going with the hamburger?

Using 「なる」 with i-adjectives

Vocabulary

1. 去年【きょ・ねん】 - last year
2. ～から (particle) - from ～
3. 背【せ】 - height
4. 高い【たか・い】 (i-adj) - high; tall; expensive
5. なる (u-verb) - to become
6. 運動【うん・どう】 - exercise
7. する (exception) - to do
8. ～から (particle) - ～ so
9. 強い【つよ・い】 (i-adj) - strong
10. 勉強【べん・きょう】 - study
11. たくさん - a lot (amount)
12. 頭【あたま】 - head
13. いい (i-adj) - good

Because the 「に」 particle is a target particle that is used for nouns and by extension na-adjectives, we need to use something else to show that something is becoming an i-adjective. Since "becoming" expresses a change in state, it makes sense to describe this process using an adverb. In fact, you'll notice that we were already using adverbs (of a sort) in the previous section by using 「に」 with na-adjectives.

1. 去年から背が高くなったね。
Your height has gotten taller from last year, huh?
2. 運動しているから、強くなる。
I will become stronger because I am exercising.
3. 勉強をたくさんしたから、頭がよくなった。
Since I studied a lot, I became smarter. (lit: head became better)

Using 「なる」 and 「する」 with verbs

Vocabulary

1. 海外 【かい・ がい】 - overseas
2. 行く 【い・ く】 (u-verb) - to go
3. こと - event, matter
4. なる (u-verb) - to become
5. 毎日 【まい・ にち】 - everyday
6. 肉 【にく】 - meat
7. 食べる 【た・ べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
8. する (exception) - to do
9. 日本 【に・ ほん】 - Japan
10. 来る 【く・ る】 (exception) - to come
11. 寿司 【すし】 - sushi
12. 一年間 【いち・ ねん・ かん】 - span of 1 year
13. 練習 【れん・ しゅう】 - practice
14. ピアノ - piano
15. 弾く 【ひ・ く】 (u-verb) - to play (piano, guitar)
16. 地下 【ち・ か】 - underground
17. 入る 【はい・ る】 (u-verb) - to enter
18. 富士山 【ふ・ じ・ さん】 - Mt. Fuji
19. 見える 【み・ える】 (ru-verb) - to be visible

You may be wondering how to use 「なる」 and 「する」 with verbs since there's no way to directly modify a verb with another verb. The simple solution is to add a generic noun such as a generic event: こと (事) or an appearance/manner: よう (様) . These nouns don't refer to anything specific and are used to describe something else. In this case, they allow us to describe verbs in the same manner as nouns. Here are some examples of how to use these generic nouns with 「する」 and 「なる」 .

1. 海外に行くことになった。

It's been decided that I will go abroad. (lit: It became the event of going abroad.)

2. 毎日、肉を食べるようになった。

It became so that I eat meat everyday. (lit: It became the appearance of eating meat everyday.)

3. 海外に行くことにした。

I decided I will go abroad. (lit: I did toward the event of going abroad.)

4. 毎日、肉を食べるようにする。

I will try to eat meat everyday. (lit: I will do toward the manner of eating meat everyday.)

You can modify a verb with 「なる」 or 「する」 by first making it into a noun clause and then treating it just like a regular noun. Pretty clever, huh? I hope the literal translations give you a sense of why the example sentences mean what they do. For instance, in the fourth example, 「～ようにする」 translates into "to make an effort toward..." but in Japanese, it's really only a target towards acting in a certain manner.

Since potential verbs describe a state of feasibility rather than an action (remember, that's why the 「を」 particle couldn't be used), it is often used in conjunction with 「～ようになる」 to describe a change in manner to a state of feasibility. Let's take this opportunity to get some potential conjugation practice in.

1. 日本に来て、寿司が食べられるようになった。

After coming to Japan, I became able to eat sushi.

2. 一年間練習したから、ピアノが弾けるようになった。

Because I practiced for one year, I became able to play the piano.

3. 地下に入って、富士山が見えなくなった。

After going underground, Fuji-san became not visible.

Conditionals

How to say "if" in Japanese

This whole section is dedicated to learning how to say "if" in Japanese. Oh, if only it was as simple as English. In Japanese, there's four (count them, four) ways to say "if"! Thankfully, the conjugations are sparse and easy especially since you don't have to deal with tenses.

Expressing natural consequence using 「と」

Vocabulary

1. ボール - ball
2. 落とす 【お・ とす】 (u-verb) - to drop
3. 落ちる 【お・ ちる】 (ru-verb) - to fall
4. 電気 【でん・ き】 - electricity; (electric) light
5. 消す 【け・ す】 (u-verb) - to erase
6. 暗い 【くら・ い】 (i-adj) - dark
7. 学校 【がっ・ こう】 - school
8. 行く 【い・ く】 (u-verb) - to go
9. 友達 【とも・ だち】 - friend
10. 会う 【あ・ う】 (u-verb) - to meet
11. たくさん - a lot (amount)
12. 太る 【ふと・ る】 (u-verb) - to become fatter
13. 先生 【せん・ せい】 - teacher
14. きっと - for sure
15. 年上 【とし・ うえ】 - older

We'll first cover the simplest type of "if" which is the natural consequence conditional. This means that if [X] happens, [Y] will happen as a natural consequence. No question about it. If I drop a ball, it will fall to the ground. If I turn off the lights at night, it will get dark. We can express this type of condition in the following format.

Rules for using the conditional 「と」

1. Attach 「と」 to the condition followed by the result that would occur should the condition be satisfied
= [Condition] + と + [Result]
2. State-of-being must be made explicit
= [State-of-being] + だ と + [Result]

Examples

1. ボールを落すと落ちる。
If you drop the ball, it will fall.
2. 電気を消すと暗くなる。
If you turn off the lights, it will get dark.

These examples are designed to show how 「と」 is used to express natural consequence. However, even if the statement isn't a natural consequence in itself, the 「と」 will tell the audience that it is nevertheless expected to be a natural consequence.

1. 学校に行かないと友達と会えないよ。
If you don't go to school, you can't meet your friends.
2. たくさん食べると太るよ。
If you eat a lot, you will get fat, for sure.
3. 先生だと、きっと年上なんじゃないですか？
If he's a teacher, he must be older for sure, right?

The "for sure" part is the implied meaning supplied by the 「と」. The speaker is saying that the following condition will occur in that situation, no matter what. As you can see from the last example, if the condition is a state-of-being, it must be expressed so explicitly using 「だ」. This applies to all non-conjugated nouns and na-adjectives as I'm sure you're used to by now. This will also help prevent confusion with other types of 「と」.

Contextual conditionals using 「なら (ば) 」

Vocabulary

1. 皆 【みんな】 - everybody
2. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
3. 私 【わたし】 - me, myself, I
4. 言う 【い・う】 (u-verb) - to say
5. 問題 【もん・だい】 - problem
6. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
7. 図書館 【と・しょ・かん】 - library
8. あそこ - over there

Another relatively easy to understand type of "if" is the contextual conditional. You can use this particle to express what will happen given a certain context. For example, if you wanted to say, "Well, if everybody's going, I'm going too" you would use the 「なら」 conditional because you are saying that you will go in the context of everybody else going. The contextual conditional always requires a context in which the conditional occurs. For instance, you would use it for saying things like, "If *that's* what you are talking about..." or "If *that's* the case, then..."

In a sense, you are explaining what would occur if you assume a certain condition is satisfied. In other words, you are saying "if given a certain context, here is what will happen." You will see this reflected in the English translations as the phrase "if given" in the examples.

The 「なら」 is attached to the context in which the conditional occurs. The format is the same as the 「と」 conditional, however, you must not attach the declarative 「だ」.

Rules for using the contextual conditional 「なら」

1. Attach 「なら」 to the context in which the conditional would occur
= [Assumed Context] + なら + [Result]
2. You must not attach the declarative 「だ」.

Examples

1. みんなが行く なら 私も行く。
If given that everybody is going, then I'll go too.
2. アリスさんが言う なら 問題ないよ。
If given that Alice-san says so, there's no problem.

Example Dialogue

アリス：図書館はどこですか。

Alice: Where is the library?

ボブ：図書館なら、あそこです。

Bob: If given that you're talking about the library, then it's over there.

The following is incorrect.

- 図書館だならあそこです。

You can also decide to use 「ならば」 instead of just 「なら」. This means exactly the same thing except that it has a more formal nuance.

General conditionals using 「ば」

Vocabulary

1. 食べる 【た・ べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
2. 待つ 【ま・ つ】 (u-verb) - to wait
3. おかしい (i-adj) - funny
4. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
5. 学生 【がく・ せい】 - student
6. 暇 【ひま】 - free (as in not busy)
7. 友達 【とも・ だち】 - friend
8. 会う 【あ・ う】 (u-verb) - to meet
9. 買い物 【か・ い・ もの】 - shopping
10. 行く 【い・ く】 (u-verb) - to go
11. お金 【お・ かね】 - money
12. いい (i-adj) - good
13. 楽しい 【たの・ しい】 (i-adj) - fun
14. 私 【わたし】 - me; myself; I
15. 病気 【びょう・ き】 - disease; sickness
16. なる (u-verb) - to become

The next type of conditional just expresses a regular "if" condition without any assumptions or embedded meanings. The conjugation rules for the 「ば」 conditional is below. Note, the conjugation rule for nouns and na-adjectives is actually using the verb 「ある」 in 「である」, a formal expression we'll learn much later.

Conjugation Rules for 「ば」

- **For verbs:** Change the last /u/ vowel sound to the equivalent /e/ vowel sound and attach 「ば」

Examples

1. 食べる → 食べれ → 食べれば
2. 待っ → 待て → 待てば

- **For i-adjectives or negatives ending in 「ない」:** Drop the last 「い」 and attach 「ければ」.

Examples

1. おかしい → おかしければ
2. ない → なければ

- **For nouns and na-adjectives:** Attach 「であれば」

Examples

1. 学生 → 学生であれば
2. 暇 → 暇であれば

Examples

1. 友達に会えれば、買い物に行きます。
If I can meet with my friend, we will go shopping.
2. お金があればいいね。
If I had money, it would be good, huh?
3. 楽しければ、私も行く。
If it's fun, I'll go too.
4. 楽しくなければ、私も行かない。
If it's not fun, I'll also not go.
5. 食べなければ病気になるよ。
If you don't eat, you will become sick.

Past conditional using 「たら (ば) 」

Vocabulary

1. 自動【じ・ どう】 - automatic
2. 待つ【ま・ つ】 (u-verb) - to wait
3. 読む【よ・ む】 (u-verb) - to read
4. 忙しい【いそが・ しい】 (i-adj) - busy
5. 暇【ひま】 - free (as in not busy)
6. 遊ぶ【あそ・ ぶ】 (u-verb) - to play
7. 行く【い・ く】 (u-verb) - to go
8. 学生【がく・ せい】 - student
9. 割引【わり・ びき】 - discount
10. 買う【か・ う】 (u-verb) - to buy
11. 友達【とも・ だち】 - friend
12. 会う【あ・ う】 (u-verb) - to meet
13. 買い物【か・ い・ もの】 - shopping
14. お金【お・ かね】 - money
15. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
16. いい (i-adj) - good
17. 家【1) うち; 2) いえ】 - 1) one's own home; 2) house
18. 帰る【かえ・ る】 (u-verb) - to go home
19. 誰【だれ】 - who
20. いる (ru-verb) - to exist (animate)
21. アメリカ - America
22. たくさん - a lot (amount)
23. 太る【ふと・ る】 (u-verb) - to become fatter

I call this next conditional the past conditional because it is produced by taking the past tense and just adding 「ら」. It is commonly called the 「たら」 conditional because all past-tense ends with 「た / だ」 and so it always becomes 「たら / だら」. Like the 「ば」 conditional, it is also a general conditional.

Conjugation Rule for 「たら (ば) 」

- First change the noun, adjective, or verb to its past tense and attach 「ら」

Examples

1. 自動 → 自動だった → 自動だったら
2. 待つ → 待った → 待ったら
3. 読む → 読んだ → 読んだら
4. 忙しい → 忙しかった → 忙しかったら

Examples

1. 暇だったら、遊びに行くよ。
If I am free, I will go play.
2. 学生だったら、学生割引で買えます。
If you're a student, you can buy with a student discount.

For i-adjectives and verbs, it is very difficult to differentiate between the two types of conditionals, and you can make life easier for yourself by considering them to be the same. However there is a small difference in that the 「たら」 conditional focuses on what happens after the condition. This is another reason why I call this the past conditional because the condition is "in the past" (not literally) and we're interested in the result not the condition. The 「ば」 conditional, on the other hand, focuses on the conditional part.

Let's compare the difference in nuance.

Example 1

- A : 友達に会えれば、買い物に行きます。
A: We will go shopping, if I can meet with my friend.
- B : 友達に会えたら、買い物に行きます。
B: If I can meet with my friend, we will go shopping.

Example 2

- A : お金があればいいね。
A: It would be good, if I had money, huh?
- B : お金があったらいいね。
B: If I had money, it would be good, huh?

Going by the context, the 「～たら」 form sounds more natural for both examples because it doesn't seem like we're really focusing on the condition itself. We're probably more interested in what's going to happen once we meet the friend or how nice it would be if we had money.

The past conditional is the only type of conditional where the result can be in the past. It may seem strange to have an "if" when the result has already taken place. Indeed, in this usage, there really is no "if", it's just a way of expressing surprise at the result of the condition. This has little to do with conditionals but it is explained here because the grammatical structure is the same.

1. 家に帰ったら、誰もいなかった。
When I went home, there was no one there. (unexpected result)
2. アメリカに行ったら、たくさん太りました。
As a result of going to America, I got really fat. (unexpected result)

You can also use 「たら**ば**」 instead of 「たら」. Similar to 「**な**らば」, this means exactly the same thing except that it has a more formal nuance.

How does 「もし」 fit into all of this?

Vocabulary

1. もし - if by any chance
2. いい (i-adj) - good
3. 映画 【えい・が】 - movie
4. 観る 【み・る】 (ru-verb) - to watch
5. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
6. 時間 【じ・かん】 - time
7. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
8. 明日 【あした】 - tomorrow

Some of you may be aware of the word 「もし」 which means "if" and may be wondering how it fits into all of this. Well, if you want to say a conditional, you need to use one of the conditionals discussed above. 「もし」 is really a supplement to add a sense of uncertainty on whether the condition is true. For instance, you might use it when you want to make an invitation and you don't want to presume like the following example.

1. もしよかったら、映画を観に行きますか？
If by any chance it's ok with you, go to watch movie?
2. もし時間がないなら、明日でもいいよ。
If given that there's no time, tomorrow is fine as well. (Not certain whether there is no time)

Expressing "must" or "have to"

When there's something that must or must not be done

In life, there are things that we must or must not do whether it's taking out the trash or doing our homework. We will cover how to say this in Japanese because it is a useful expression and it also ties in well with the previous section. We will also learn how to say the expression, "You don't have to..." to finish off this section.

Using 「だめ」, 「いけない」, and 「ならない」 for things that must not be done

Vocabulary

1. 駄目 【だめ】 - no good
2. ここ - here
3. 入る 【はい・る】 (u-verb) - to enter
4. それ - that
5. 食べる 【たべ・る】 (ru-verb) - to eat
6. 夜 【よる】 - evening
7. 遅い 【おそ・い】 (i-adj) - late
8. ～まで (particle) - until ～
9. 電話 【でん・わ】 - phone
10. する (exception) - to do
11. 早い 【はや・い】 (i-adj) - fast; early
12. 寝る 【ね・る】 (ru-verb) - to sleep

If you're not familiar with the word 「だめ」 (駄目), though it can be used in many different ways it essentially means "no good". The other two key words in this section are 「いけない」 and 「ならない」 and they have essentially the same basic meaning as 「だめ」. However, while 「いけない」 can be used by itself, 「ならない」 must only be used in the grammar presented here. In addition, while 「いけない」 and 「ならない」 conjugate like i-adjectives they are not actual adjectives. Let's learn how to use these words to express things that must not be done.

How to say: Must not [verb]

- Take the te-form of the verb, add the 「は」 (wa) particle and finally attach either 「だめ」、「いけない」、or 「ならない」.

Example

入る → 入って + は + だめ / いけない / ならない = 入ってはだめ / 入ってはいけない / 入ってはならない

1. ここに入ってはいけません。
You must not enter here.
2. それを食べてはだめ！
You can't (must not) eat that!
3. 夜、遅くまで電話してはならない。
You must not use the phone until late at night.
4. 早く寝てはなりませんでした。

Wasn't allowed to sleep early.

The difference between 「だめ」、 「いけない」、 and 「ならない」 is that, first of all, 「だめ」 is casual. While 「いけない」 and 「ならない」 are basically identical, 「ならない」 is generally more for things that apply to more than one person like rules and policies.

Expressing things that must be done

Vocabulary

1. 毎日 【まい・ にち】 - everyday
2. 学校 【がっ・ こう】 - school
3. 行く 【い・ く】 (u-verb) - to go
4. 宿題 【しゅく・ だい】 - homework
5. する (exception) - to do

You may have predicted that the opposite of "You must not do" would use 「いける」 or 「なる」 because they look like the positive version of 「いけない」 and 「ならない」. However, 「いけない」 and 「ならない」 must always be negative, so this is not correct. In actuality, we still use the same 「だめ / いけない / ならない」 and use the opposite of the verb that goes in front of it instead. This double negative can be kind of confusing at first but you will get used to it with practice. There are three ways to conjugate the verb before adding 「だめ / いけない / ならない」 and two of them involve conditionals so aren't you glad that you just learned conditionals in the previous section?

How to say: Must [verb]

1. Negative te-form + 「は」 (wa) particle + だめ / いけない / ならない
2. Negative verb + 「と」 conditional + だめ / いけない / ならない
3. Negative verb + 「ば」 conditional + だめ / いけない / ならない

The first method is the same as the "must not do" grammar form except that we simply negated the verb.

1. 毎日学校に行かなくてはなりません。
Must go to school everyday.
2. 宿題をしなくてはいけなかった
Had to do homework.

The second method uses the natural conditional that we learned in the last lesson. Literally, it means if you don't do something, then it automatically leads to the fact that it is no good. (In other words, you must do it.) However, people tend to use it for situations beyond the natural consequence characterization that we learned from the last section because it's shorter and easier to use than the other two types of grammar.

1. 毎日学校に行かないとだめです。
Must go to school everyday.

2. 宿題をしないといけない

Have to do homework.

The third method is similar to the second except that it uses a different type of conditional as explained in the last lesson. With the 「ば」 conditional, it can be used for a wider range of situations. Note that since the verb is always negative, for the 「ば」 conditional, we will always be removing the last 「い」 and adding 「ければ」.

1. 毎日学校に行かなければいけません。

Must go to school everyday.

2. 宿題をしなければだめだった。

Had to do homework.

It may seem like I just breezed through a whole lot of material because there are three grammar forms and 「だめ / いけない / ならない」 adding up to nine possible combinations (3x3). However, some combinations are more common than others but I did not explicitly point out which were more common because any combination is technically correct and going over style would merely confuse at this point. Also, keep in mind that there is nothing essentially new in terms of conjugation rules. We already covered conditionals in the last lesson and adding the wa particle to the te-form in the beginning of this section.

Reality Check

Although we spent the last section explaining 「～なければ」 and 「～なくては」, the reality is that because they are so long, they are practically never used in real conversations. While they are often used in a written context, in actual speech, people usually use the 「と」 conditional or the various shortcuts described below. In casual speech, the 「と」 conditional is the most prevalent type of conditional. Though I explained in depth the meaning associated with the 「と」 conditional, you have to take it with a grain of salt here because people are inherently lazy.

Various short-cuts for the lazy

Vocabulary

1. 勉強【べん・きょう】 - study
2. する (exception) - to do
3. ご飯【ご・はん】 - rice; meal
4. 食べる【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
5. 学校【がっ・こう】 - school
6. 行く【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
7. ここ - here
8. 入る【はい・る】 (u-verb) - to enter
9. 駄目【だめ】 - no good
10. 死ぬ【し・ぬ】 (u-verb) - to die

You may have been grumbling and complaining about how long most of the expressions are just to say you must do something. You can end up with up to eight additional syllables just to say "I have to..."!

Well, others have thought the same before and people usually use short abbreviated versions of 「なくては」 and 「なければ」 in casual speech. Teachers are often reluctant to teach these overly familiar expressions because they are so much easier to use which is bad for times when they might not be appropriate. But, on the other hand, if you don't learn casual expressions, it makes it difficult to understand your friends (or would-be friends if you only knew how to speak less stiffly!). So here they are but take care to properly practice the longer forms so that you will be able to use them for the appropriate occasions.

Casual abbreviations for things that must be done

1. Simply replace 「なくて」 with 「なくちゃ」
2. Simply replace 「なければ」 with 「なきゃ」

Right now, you may be saying, "What the?" because the "abbreviations" are about the same length as what we've already covered. The secret here is that, unlike the expressions we learned so far, you can just leave the 「だめ / いけない / ならない」 part out altogether!

1. 勉強しなくちゃ。
Gotta study.
2. ご飯を食ベなきゃ。
Gotta eat.

The 「と」 conditional is also used by itself to imply 「だめ / いけない / ならない」.

- 学校に行かないと。
Gotta go to school.

There is another 「ちゃ」 abbreviation for things that you must not do. However, in this case, you cannot leave out 「だめ / いけない / ならない」. Since this *is* a casual abbreviation, 「だめ」 is used in most cases.

One very important difference for this casual form is that verbs that end in 「む」、「ぶ」、「ぬ」 use 「じゃ」 instead of 「ちゃ」. Essentially, all the verbs that end in 「んだ」 for past tense fall in this category.

Casual abbreviations for things that must not be done

1. Replace 「ては」 with 「ちゃ」
2. Replace 「では」 with 「じゃ」

1. ここに入っちゃだめだよ。
You can't enter here.
2. 死んじゃだめだよ！ - You can't die!

On a final note, in general, 「ちゃ」 sounds a bit cutesy or girly. You've already seen an example of this with the 「ちゃん」 suffix. Similarly, 「なくちゃ」 also sounds a bit cutesy or childish.

Saying something is ok to do or not do

Vocabulary

1. 全部 【ぜん・ぶ】 - everything
2. 食べる 【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
3. いい (i-adj) - good
4. 飲む 【の・む】 (u-verb) - to drink
5. 大丈夫 【だい・じょう・ぶ】 (na-adj) - ok
6. 構う 【かま・う】 (u-verb) - to mind; to be concerned about
7. もう - already
8. 帰る 【かえ・る】 (u-verb) - to go home
9. これ - this
10. ちょっと - just a little
11. 見る 【み・る】 (ru-verb) - to see

Now let's learn how to say either that it's ok to do or not do something. I decided to shove this section in here because in Japanese, this is essential how to say that you don't have to do something (by saying it's ok to not do it). The grammar itself is also relatively easy to pick up and makes for a short section.

By simply using the te-form and the 「も」 particle, you are essentially saying, "even if you do X..." Common words that come after this include 「いい」, 「大丈夫」, or 「構わない」. Some examples will come in handy.

1. 全部食べてもいいよ。
You can go ahead and eat it all. (lit: Even if you eat it all, it's good, you know.)
2. 全部食べなくてもいいよ。
You don't have to eat it all. (lit: Even if you don't eat it all, it's good, you know.)
3. 全部飲んでも大丈夫だよ。
It's ok if you drink it all. (lit: Even if you drink it all, it's OK, you know.)
4. 全部飲んでも構わないよ。
I don't mind if you drink it all. (lit: Even if you drink it all, I don't mind, you know.)

In casual speech, 「～てもいい」 sometimes get shortened to just 「～ていい」 (or 「～でもいい」 instead of 「～でもいい」).

1. もう帰っていい？
Can I go home already?
2. これ、ちょっと見ていい？
Can I take a quick look at this?

Desire and Suggestions

How to get your way in Japan

We will now learn how to say what you want either by just coming out and saying it or by making discreet suggestions. The major topics we will cover will be the 「たい」 conjugation and the volitional form. We will also learn specialized uses of the 「たら」 and 「ば」 conditionals to offer advice.

Verbs you want to do with 「たい」

Vocabulary

- 1. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
- 2. 何 【なに】 - what
- 3. する (exception) - to do
- 4. 温泉 【おん・せん】 - hot spring
- 5. ケーキ - cake
- 6. 食べる 【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
- 7. ずっと - long; far
- 8. 一緒 【いっ・しょ】 - together
- 9. いる (ru-verb) - to exist (animate)
- 10. 犬 【いぬ】 - dog
- 11. 遊ぶ 【あそ・ぶ】 (u-verb) - to play

You can express verbs that you *want* to perform with the 「たい」 form. All you need to do is add 「たい」 to the stem of the verb. However, unlike most conjugations we learned where the verb turns into a ru-verb, this form actually transforms the verb into an i-adjective (notice how 「たい」 conveniently ends in 「い」). This makes sense because the conjugated form is a description of something that you want to do. Once you have the 「たい」 form, you can then conjugate it the same as you would any other i-adjective. However, the 「たい」 form is different from regular i-adjectives because it is derived from a verb. This means that all the particles we normally associate with verbs such as 「を」、「に」、「へ」、or 「で」 can all be used with the 「たい」 form, which is not true for regular i-adjectives. Here's a chart just for you.

「たい」 conjugations

	Positive	Negative
Non-Past	行きたい	行きたくない
Past	行きたかった	行きたくなかった

Examples

- 1. 何をしたいですか。 What do you want to do?
- 2. 温泉に行きたい。 I want to go to hot spring.
- 3. ケーキ、食べたくないの？ You don't want to eat cake?
- 4. 食べたくなかったけど食べたくなった。 I didn't want to eat it but I became wanting to eat.

Example 4 was very awkward to translate but is quite simple in Japanese if you refer to the section about using 「なる」 with i-adjectives". The past tense of the verb 「なる」 was used to create "became want to eat". Here's a tongue twister using the negative 「～たくない」 and past-tense of 「なる」 : 「食べたくなくなった」 meaning "became not wanting to eat".

This may seem obvious but 「ある」 cannot have a 「たい」 form because inanimate objects

cannot want anything. However, 「いる」 can be used with the 「たい」 form in examples like the one below.

- ずっと一緒にいたい。 I want to be together forever. (lit: Want to exist together for long time.)

Also, you can only use the 「たい」 form for the first-person because you cannot read other people's mind to see what they want to do. For referring to anyone beside yourself, it is normal to use expressions such as, "I think he wants to..." or "She said that she wants to..." We will learn how to say such expressions in a later lesson. Of course, if you're asking a question, you can just use the 「たい」 form because you're not presuming to know anything.

- 犬と遊びたいですか。 Do you want to play with dog?

Indicating things you want or want done using 「欲しい」

Vocabulary

1. 欲しい 【ほ・しい】 (i-adj) - wanted; desirable
2. 好き 【す・き】 (na-adj) - likable; desirable
3. 大きい 【おお・きい】 (i-adj) - big
4. 縫いぐるみ 【ぬ・いぐるみ】 - stuffed doll
5. 全部 【ぜん・ぶ】 - everything
6. 食べる 【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
7. 部屋 【へ・や】 - room
8. きれい (na-adj) - pretty; clean

In English, we employ a verb to say that we want something. In Japanese, "to want" is actually an i-adjective and not a verb. We saw something similar with 「好き」 which is an adjective while "to like" in English is a verb. While I didn't get too much into the workings of 「好き」, I have dedicated a whole section to 「欲しい」 because it means, "to want something done" when combined with the te-form of a verb. We will learn a more polite and appropriate way to make requests in the "Making Requests" lesson instead of saying, "I want this done."

Though not a set rule, whenever words come attached to the te-form of a verb to serve a special grammatical function, it is customary to write it in hiragana. This is because kanji is already used for the verb and the attached word becomes part of that verb.

Examples

1. 大きい縫いぐるみが欲しい！ I want a big stuffed doll!
2. 全部食べてほしいんだけど・・・ 。 I want it all eaten but...
3. 部屋をきれいにしてほしいのよ。 It is that I want the room cleaned up, you know.

Like I mentioned, there are more appropriate ways to ask for things which we won't go into until later. This grammar is not used too often but is included for completeness.

Making a motion to do something using the volitional form (casual)

Vocabulary

1. 食べる 【た・ べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
2. 入る 【はい・ る】 (u-verb) - to enter
3. 着る 【き・ る】 (ru-verb) - to wear
4. 信じる 【しん・ じる】 (ru-verb) - to believe
5. 寝る 【ね・ る】 (ru-verb) - to sleep
6. 起きる 【お・ きる】 (ru-verb) - to wake; to occur
7. 出る 【で・ る】 (ru-verb) - to come out
8. 掛ける 【か・ ける】 (ru-verb) - to hang
9. 捨てる 【す・ てる】 (ru-verb) - to throw away
10. 調べる 【しら・ べる】 (ru-verb) - to investigate
11. 話す 【はな・ す】 (u-verb) - to speak
12. 書く 【か・ く】 (u-verb) - to write
13. 待つ 【ま・ つ】 (u-verb) - to wait
14. 飲む 【の・ む】 (u-verb) - to drink
15. 取る 【と・ る】 (u-verb) - to take
16. 聞く 【き・ く】 (u-verb) - to ask; to listen
17. 泳ぐ 【およ・ ぐ】 (u-verb) - to swim
18. 遊ぶ 【あそ・ ぶ】 (u-verb) - to play
19. 直る 【なお・ る】 (u-verb) - to be fixed
20. 死ぬ 【し・ ぬ】 (u-verb) - to die
21. 買う 【か・ う】 (u-verb) - to buy
22. する (exception) - to do
23. 来る 【く・ る】 (exception) - to come
24. 今日 【きょう】 - today
25. 何 【なに】 - what
26. テーマパーク - theme park
27. 行く 【い・ く】 (u-verb) - to go
28. 明日 【あした】 - tomorrow
29. カレー - curry

The term volitional here means a will to do something. In other words, the volitional form indicates that someone is setting out to do something. In the most common example, this simply translates into the English "let's" or "shall we?" but we'll also see how this form can be used to express an effort to do something in a lesson further along.

To conjugate verbs into the volitional form for casual speech, there are two different rules for ru-verbs and u-verbs. For ru-verbs, you simply remove the 「る」 and add 「よう」. For u-verbs, you replace the / u / vowel sound with the / o / vowel sound and add 「う」.

Conjugations rules for the casual volitional form

- **For ru-verbs:** Remove the 「る」 and add 「よう」 Example: 食べる → 食べ + よう → 食べよう
- **For u-verbs:** Replace the / u / vowel sound with the / o / vowel sound and add 「う」 Example: 入る → 入ろ + う → 入ろう

Here is a list of verbs you should be used to seeing by now.

Sample ru-verbs

Plain	Volitional
食べ <u>る</u>	食べ <u>よう</u>
着 <u>る</u>	着 <u>よう</u>
信じ <u>る</u>	信じ <u>よう</u>
寝 <u>る</u>	寝 <u>よう</u>
起き <u>る</u>	起き <u>よう</u>
出 <u>る</u>	出 <u>よう</u>
掛 <u>ける</u>	掛 <u>けよう</u>
捨 <u>てる</u>	捨 <u>てよう</u>
調 <u>べる</u>	調 <u>べよう</u>

Sample u-verbs

Plain	Volitional
話 <u>す</u>	話 <u>そう</u>
聞 <u>く</u>	聞 <u>こう</u>
泳 <u>ぐ</u>	泳 <u>ごう</u>
遊 <u>ぶ</u>	遊 <u>ぼう</u>
待 <u>つ</u>	待 <u>とう</u>
飲 <u>む</u>	飲 <u>もう</u>
直 <u>る</u>	直 <u>ろう</u>
死 <u>ぬ</u>	死 <u>のう</u>
買 <u>う</u>	買 <u>おう</u>

Exception Verbs

Plain	Volitional
する	しよう
くる	こよう

Examples

I doubt you will ever use 「死のう」 (let's die) but I left it in for completeness. Here are some more realistic examples.

1. 今日は何をしようか？ What shall (we) do today?
2. テーマパークに行こう！ Let's go to theme park!
3. 明日は何を食べようか？ What shall (we) eat tomorrow?
4. カレーを食べよう！ Let's eat curry!

Remember, since you're setting out to do something, it doesn't make sense to have this verb in the past tense. Therefore, there is only one tense and if you were to replace 「明日」 in the third example with, let's say, 「昨日」 then the sentence would make no sense.

Making a motion to do something using the volitional form (polite)

Vocabulary

1. 食べる 【た・ べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
2. 入る 【はい・ る】 (u-verb) - to enter
3. する (exception) - to do
4. 来る 【く・ る】 (exception) - to come
5. 寝る 【ね・ る】 (ru-verb) - to sleep
6. 行く 【い・ く】 (u-verb) - to go
7. 遊ぶ 【あそ・ ぶ】 (u-verb) - to play
8. 今日 【きょう】 - today
9. 何 【なに】 - what
10. テーマパーク - theme park
11. 明日 【あした】 - tomorrow
12. カレー - curry

The conjugation for the polite form is even simpler. All you have to do is add 「～ましょう」 to the stem of the verb. Similar to the masu-form, verbs in this form must always come at the end of the sentence. In fact, all polite endings must always come at the end and nowhere else as we've already seen.

Conjugations rules for the polite volitional form

- **For all verbs:** Add 「～ましょう」 to the stem of the verb
 1. 食べる → 食べ + ましょう → 食べましょう
 2. 入る → 入り + ましょう → 入りましょう

Sample verbs

Plain	Volitional
する	し <u>ましょう</u>
くる	き <u>ましょう</u>
寝る	寝 <u>ましょう</u>
行く	行き <u>ましょう</u>
遊ぶ	遊び <u>ましょう</u>

Examples

Again, there's nothing new here, just the polite version of the volitional form.

1. 今日は何をしましうか？ What shall (we) do today?
2. テーマパークに行きましう！ Let's go to theme park!
3. 明日は何を食べましうか？ What shall (we) eat tomorrow?
4. カレーを食べましう！ Let's eat curry!

Making Suggestions using the 「ば」 or 「たら」 conditional

Vocabulary

1. 銀行【ぎん・こう】 - bank
2. 行く【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
3. たまに - once in a while
4. 両親【りょう・しん】 - parents
5. 話す【はな・す】 (u-verb) - to speak

You can make suggestions by using the 「ば」 or 「たら」 conditional and adding 「どう」. This literally means, "If you do [X], how is it?" In English, this would become, "How about doing [X]?" Grammatically, there's nothing new here but it is a commonly used set phrase.

Examples

1. 銀行に行ったらどうですか。 How about going to bank?
2. たまにご両親と話せばどう？ How about talking with your parents once in a while?

Acting on relative clauses

In the section about modifying relative clauses, we learned how to treat a relative clause like an adjective to directly modify a noun. We will extend the functionality of relative clauses by learning how to perform an action on a relative clause. Obviously, we cannot simply attach the 「を」 particle to a relative clause because the 「を」 particle only applies to noun phrases. We need something to encapsulate the relative clause into a unit that we can perform actions on. This is done by making a quoted phrase.

While in English, you can just add quotes and a comma to make a quotation, Japanese requires attaching 「と」 at the end of the quote. This is completely different from the 「と」 particle and the 「と」 conditional. Unlike quotes in English, we can perform many different types of actions on the quote besides the standard "he said", "she said", etc. For example, we can perform the action, "to think" or "to hear" to produce phrases such as, "I think [clause]" or "I heard [clause]" This is very important in Japanese because Japanese people seldom affirm definite statements. This also why we will have to eventually cover many other types of grammar to express uncertainty or probability.

The direct quote

Vocabulary

1. 言う 【い・う】 (u-verb) - to say
2. 聞く 【き・く】 (u-verb) - to ask; to listen
3. 叫ぶ 【さけ・ぶ】 (u-verb) - to scream
4. 呼ぶ 【よ・ぶ】 (u-verb) - to call
5. 呟く 【つぶや・く】 (u-verb) - to mutter
6. 寒い 【さむ・い】 (i-adj) - cold
7. 今日 【きょう】 - today
8. 授業 【じゅ・ぎょう】 - class
9. 先生 【せん・せい】 - teacher
10. 田中 【た・なか】 - Tanaka (last name)

We'll learn the simplest type of quoted phrase, which is the direct quote. Basically, you are directly quoting something that was said. This is done by simply enclosing the statement in quotes, adding 「と」 and then inserting the appropriate verb. The most common verbs associated with a direct quote would be 「言う」 and 「聞く」 but you may use any verbs related to direct quotation such as: 「叫ぶ」, 「呼ぶ」, 「呟く」, etc. This type of quotation is often used for dialogue in novels and other narrative works.

Examples

1. アリスが、「寒い」と言った。
Alice said, "Cold".
2. 「今日は授業がない」と先生から聞いたんだけど。
It is that I heard from the teacher, "There is no class today."

The verb does not need to be directly connected to the relative clause. As long as the verb that applies to the relative clause comes before any other verb, you can have any number of adjectives, adverbs or nouns in between.

- 「寒い」とアリスが田中に言った。
"Cold," Alice said to Tanaka.

The interpreted quote

Vocabulary

1. 先生 【せん・ せい】 - teacher
2. 今日 【きょう】 - today
3. 授業 【じゅ・ ぎょう】 - class
4. 聞く 【き・ く】 (u-verb) - to ask; to listen
5. これ - this
6. 日本語 【に・ ほん・ ご】 - Japanese (language)
7. 何 【なに / なん】 - what
8. 言う 【い・ う】 (u-verb) - to say
9. 私 【わたし】 - me; myself; I
10. カレー - curry
11. 食べる 【た・ べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
12. 思う 【おも・ う】 (u-verb) - to think
13. 時間 【じ・ かん】 - time
14. 今 【いま】 - now
15. どこ - where
16. 行く 【い・ く】 (u-verb) - to go
17. 考える 【かんが・ える】 (ru-verb) - to think
18. 彼 【かれ】 - he; boyfriend
19. 高校生 【こう・ こう・ せい】 - high school student
20. 信じる 【しん・ じる】 (ru-verb) - to believe

The second type of quote is the quote along the lines of what someone actually said. It's not a word-for-word quote. Since this is not a direct quote, no quotations are needed. You can also express thoughts as an interpreted quote as well. By using this and the verb 「思う」 you can say you think that something is so-and-so. You will hear Japanese people use this all the time. You can also use the verb 「考える」 when you are considering something.

Examples

1. 先生から 今日は授業がないと聞いたんだけど。
I heard from the teacher that there is no class today.
2. これは、日本語で 何と言いますか。
What do you call this in Japanese? (lit: About this, what do you say in Japanese?)
3. 私は、アリス と言います。
I am called Alice. (lit: As for me, you say Alice.)

In an interpreted quote, the meaning of 「言う」 may change as you see in examples 2 and 3. Actually, as you can see from the literal translation, the meaning remains the same in Japanese but changes only when translated to normal English. (We'll learn more about various ways to use 「いう」 in the next lesson.)

Here are some examples of thoughts being used as quoted relative clauses. In example 2 below, the question marker is used with the volitional to insert an embedded question.

1. カレーを食べようと思ったけど、食べる時間がなかった。
I thought about setting out to eat curry but I didn't have time to eat.
2. 今、どこに行こうかと考えている。
Now, I'm considering where to set out to go.

Unlike the direct quotation, which you can just copy as is, if the quoted relative clause is a state-of-being for a noun or na-adjective, you have to explicitly include the declarative 「だ」 to show this.

1. 彼は、これは何だと言いましたか。
What did he say this is?
2. 彼は高校生だと聞いたけど、信じられない。
I heard that he is a high school student but I can't believe it.

Notice how 「だ」 was added to explicitly declare the state-of-being that is highlighted in the English translation. You can really see how important the 「だ」 is here by comparing the following two sentences.

- これは何だと言いましたか。
What did (he) say this is?
- 何と言いましたか。
What did (he) say?

Using 「って」 as a casual version of 「と」

Vocabulary

1. 智子 【とも・こ】 - Tomoko (first name)
2. 来年 【らい・ねん】 - next year
3. 海外 【かい・がい】 - overseas
4. もう - already
5. お金 【お・かね】 - money
6. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
7. 本当 【ほん・とう】 - real
8. 明日 【あした】 - tomorrow
9. 雨 【あめ】 - rain
10. 降る 【ふ・る】 (u-verb) - to precipitate
11. すごい (i-adj) - to a great extent
12. いい (i-adj) - good
13. 人 【ひと】 - person

You may be surprised to hear that there is a shorter and casual version of the quoted relative clause since it's already only one hiragana character, 「と」. However, the important point here is that by using this casual shortcut, you can drop the rest of the sentence and hope your audience can understand everything from context.

Examples

1. 智子は来年、海外に行くんだって。
Tomoko said that she's going overseas next year.
2. もうお金がないって。
I already told you I have no money.
3. え？何だって？
Huh? What did you say?
4. 今、時間がないって聞いたんだけど、本当？
I heard you don't have time now, is that true?
5. 今、時間がないって、本当？
You don't have time now (I heard), is that true?

「って」 can also be used to talk about practically anything, not just to quote something that was said. You can hear 「って」 being used just about everywhere in casual speech. Most of the time it is used in place of the 「は」 particle to simply bring up a topic.

1. 明日って、雨が降るんだって。
About tomorrow, I hear that it's going to rain.
2. アリスって、すごくいい人でしょ？
About Alice, she's a very good person, right?

Defining and Describing

The various uses of 「いう」

In the previous lesson, we learned how to quote a relative clause by encasing it with 「と」. This allowed us to talk about things that people have said, heard, thought, and more. We also took a look at some examples sentences that used 「と」 and 「言う」 to describe how to say something in Japanese and even what to call oneself. In this section, we will learn that with 「と」, we can use 「いう」 in a similar fashion to define, describe, and generally just talk about the thing itself. We'll also see how to do the same thing with the casual 「って」 version we first learned about in the last lesson.

Using 「いう」 to define

Vocabulary

1. 言う 【い・ う】 (u-verb) - to say
2. これ - this
3. 何 【なに / なん】 - what
4. 魚 【さかな】 - fish
5. この - this (abbr. of これの)
6. 鯛 【たい】 - tai (type of fish)
7. デパート - department store
8. どこ - where
9. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
10. 知る 【し・ る】 (u-verb) - to know
11. 友達 【とも・ だち】 - friend
12. 英語 【えい・ ご】 - English (language)
13. 意味 【い・ み】 - meaning

In the last lesson, we briefly looked at how to introduce ourselves by using 「と」 and 「いう」 . For instance, we had the following example, which Alice used to introduce herself.

- 私はアリスといいます。

I am called Alice. (lit: As for me, you say Alice.)

This sentence pattern is probably one of the first things beginner Japanese students learn in the classroom. In this case, the verb 「いう」 doesn't mean that somebody actually said something. Rather, Alice is saying that people in general say "Alice" when referring to her. While using kanji for 「いう」 is perfectly acceptable, in this case, since nothing is actually being said, using hiragana is also common.

This idea of describing what a person is known or referred to as can also be extended to objects and places. We can essentially define and identify anything we want by using 「という」 in this manner. As you can imagine, this is particularly useful for us because it allows us to ask what things are called in Japanese and for the definition of words we don't know yet.

Examples

1. これは、なんという魚ですか。
What is this fish referred to as?
2. この魚は、鯛といいます。
This fish is known as "Tai".
3. ルミネというデパートはどこにあるか、知っていますか？
Do you know where the department store called "Lumine" is?
4. 「友達」は、英語で「friend」という意味です。
The meaning of "tomodachi" in English is "friend".

Using 「いう」 to describe anything

Vocabulary

1. 主人公【しゅ・じん・こう】 - main character
2. 犯人【はん・にん】 - criminal
3. 一番【いち・ばん】 - best; first
4. 面白い【おも・しろ・い】 (i-adj) - interesting
5. 日本人【に・ほん・じん】 - Japanese person
6. お酒【お・さけ】 - alcohol
7. 弱い【よわ・い】 (i-adj) - weak
8. 言う【い・う】 (u-verb) - to say
9. 本当【ほん・とう】 - real
10. 独身【どく・しん】 - single; unmarried
11. 嘘【うそ】 - lie
12. リブート - reboot
13. パソコン - computer, PC
14. こう - (things are) this way
15. そう - (things are) that way
16. ああ - (things are) that way
17. どう - how
18. 再起動【さい・き・どう】 - reboot
19. あんた - you (slang)
20. いつも - always
21. 時【とき】 - time
22. 来る【く・る】 (exception) - to come
23. 困る【こま・る】 (u-verb) - to be bothered, troubled
24. 人【ひと】 - person
25. 結婚【けっ・こん】 - marriage
26. 出来る【で・き・る】 (ru-verb) - to be able to do
27. 幸せ【しあわ・せ】 - happiness
28. なる (u-verb) - to become
29. 思う【おも・う】 (u-verb) - to think
30. 大学【だい・がく】 - college
31. 行く【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
32. 意味【い・み】 - meaning

We learned how to use 「という」 to describe what something is known or referred to as. However, we can take this idea even further by attaching two relative clauses. At this point, 「いう」 is so abstract that it doesn't even really have a meaning. When a relative clause is encapsulated with 「と」, you must have a verb to go along with it and 「いう」 is simply being used as a generic verb to enable us to talk about any relative clause. This allows us to describe and explain just about anything ranging from a single word to complete sentences. As you can imagine, this construction is quite useful and employed quite often in Japanese.

Examples

1. 主人公が犯人だったというのが一番面白かった。
The most interesting thing was that the main character was the criminal.
2. 日本人はお酒に弱いというのは本当？
Is it true that Japanese people are weak to alcohol?
3. 独身だというのは、嘘だったの？
It was a lie that you were single?
4. リブートというのは、パソコンを再起動するということです。
Reboot means to restart your computer.

We can abstract it even further by replacing the relative clause with a generic way of doing something. In this case, we use 「こう」、「そう」、「ああ」、and 「どう」, which when combined with 「いう」 means "this way", "that way", "that way (far away in an abstract sense)" and "what way" respectively.

Examples

1. あんたは、いつもこういう時に来るんだから、困るんだよ。
It's because you always come at times like these that I'm troubled.
2. そういう人と一緒に仕事をするのは、嫌だよね。
(Anybody would) dislike doing work together with that type of person, huh?
3. ああいう人と結婚できたら、幸せになれると思います。
I think you can become happy if you could marry that type of person.
4. 大学に行かないって、どういう意味なの？
What do you mean, "You're not going to go to college?"

Rephrasing and making conclusions with 「という」

Vocabulary

1. あんた - you (slang)
2. 彼女 【かの・ じょ】 - she; girlfriend
3. 友達 【とも・ だち】 - friend
4. 言う 【い・ う】 (u-verb) - to say
5. 何 【なに / なん】 - what
6. お酒 【お・ さけ】 - alcohol
7. 好き 【す・ き】 (na-adj) - likable
8. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
9. 生きる 【い・ きる】 (ru-verb) - to live
10. 多分 【た・ ぶん】 - maybe
11. 行く 【い・ く】 (u-verb) - to go
12. 思う 【おも・ う】 (u-verb) - to think
13. お金 【お・ かね】 - money
14. もう - already
15. 帰る 【かえ・ る】 (u-verb) - to go home
16. 駄目 【だめ】 - no good
17. 洋介 【よう・ すけ】 - Yousuke (first name)
18. 別れる 【わか・ れる】 (ru-verb) - to separate; to break up
19. こと - event, matter
20. 今 【いま】 - now
21. 彼氏 【かれ・ し】 - boyfriend
22. いる (ru-verb) - to exist (animate)
23. そう - (things are) that way

We can attach the question marker 「か」 to 「という」 in order to add a questioning element. This construction is used when you want to rephrase or redefine something such as the following dialogue.

Example Dialogue

A : みきちゃんは、あなたの彼女でしょう？

A: Miki-chan is your girlfriend, right?

B : う～ん、彼女というか、友達というか、なんというか・・・

B:Um, you might say girlfriend, or friend, or something...

This construction is used all the time, particularly in casual conversations. It can be used to correct something, come to a different conclusion, or even as an interjection.

Examples

1. お酒は好きというか、ないと生きていけない。

I like alcohol or rather, can't live on without it.

2. 多分行かないと思う。というか、お金がないから、行けない。

Don't think I'll go. Or rather, can't because there's no money.

3. というか、もう帰らないとだめですけど。

Rather than that, I have to go home already.

Rather than using 「か」 to rephrase a conclusion, we can also simply use 「こと」 to sum up something without rephrasing anything.

Example Dialogue

A : みきちゃんが洋介と別れたんだって。

A: I heard that Miki-chan broke up with Yousuke.

B : ということは、みきちゃんは、今彼氏がないということ？

B: Does that mean Miki-chan doesn't have a boyfriend now?

A : そう。そういうこと。

A: That's right. That's what it means.

Using 「って」 or 「て」 for 「という」

Vocabulary

1. 来年 【らい・ねん】 - next year
2. 留学 【りゅう・がく】 - study abroad
3. する (exception) - to do
4. 言う 【い・う】 (u-verb) - to say
5. 智子 【とも・こ】 - Tomoko (first name)
6. こと - event, matter
7. 駄目 【だめ】 - no good
8. 時間 【じ・かん】 - time
9. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
10. 出来る 【で・き・る】 (ru-verb) - to be able to do
11. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
12. いい (i-adj) - good
13. 皆 【みんな】 - everybody
14. 私 【わたし】 - me; myself; I
15. 今 【いま】 - now
16. 彼氏 【かれ・し】 - boyfriend
17. いる (ru-verb) - to exist (animate)
18. もう - already
19. 帰る 【かえ・る】 (u-verb) - to go home

As mentioned in the previous lesson, 「って」 is very often used in causal slang in place of 「と」, because it allows us to leave out the rest of the sentence and assume context (or just plain assumption) will take care of the rest. We already saw that we can use 「って」 to replace 「という」 as well. However, since we just learned how to use 「という」 to do much more than just simply say something, there is a limit to just how much you can leave out. In any case, 「って」 will allow us to leave out not only 「いう」 but also any accompanying particles as you can see in the following example.

Examples

1. 来年留学する というのは、智子のこと？
The studying abroad next year thing, is that Tomoko?
2. 来年留学する って 智子のこと？
The studying abroad next year thing, is that Tomoko?

「だって」 is also another phrase that leaves out just about everything. By convention, it is used to express disagreement or dissatisfaction usually to whine, complain, or to make an excuse but you can't tell what it means just from looking at it. It is an abbreviation of something along the lines of 「とはいっても」 meaning, "even if that was the case".

Example 1

A : しないとだめだよ。

A: Have to do it, you know.

B : だって、時間がないからできないよ。

B: But (even so), can't do it because there is no time.

Example 2

A : 行かなくてもいいよ。

A: Don't have to go, you know.

B : だって、みんな行くって。私も行かないと。

B: But (even so), everybody said they're going. I have to go too.

In some cases, the small 「つ」 is left out and just 「て」 is used instead of 「って」. This is done (as is usually the case for slang) in order to make things easier to say. In general, this is when there is nothing before the 「て」 or when the sound that comes before it doesn't require the explicit separation the 「つ」 gives us in order to be understood.

Examples

1. てことは、みきちゃんは、今彼氏がいなくててこと？

Does that mean Miki-chan doesn't have a boyfriend now?

2. ていうか、もう帰らないとだめですけど。

Rather than that, I have to go home already.

Since slang tends to be used in whichever way the person feels like, there are no definite rules defining whether you should use 「って」 or 「て」. However, 「て」 is generally not used to express what people have actually said or heard, which is why it wasn't covered in the last lesson.

- みきちゃんが、明日こないて。

(Can't use 「て」 for something actually said)

- みきちゃんが、明日こないって。

Miki-chan says she isn't coming tomorrow.

Saying 「ゆう」 instead of 「いう」

Vocabulary

1. もう - already
2. 帰る【かえ・る】 (u-verb) - to go home
3. そう - (things are) that way
4. こと - event, matter

Because the 「という」 construction is used so often, there are a lot of different variations and slang based on it. While I do not plan on covering all of them here, you can check out casual patterns and slang in the miscellaneous section for yet even more slang derived from 「という」.

The last thing I'm am going to briefly mention here is the use of 「ゆう」 instead of 「いう」. In conversations, it is quite normal to say 「ゆう」 instead of 「いう」. 「ゆう」 is easier to say because it is simply one letter with a long vowel sound instead of the two different vowel sounds of 「いう」.

Examples

1. てゆうか、もう帰らないとだめですけど。
Rather than that, I have to go home already.
2. そうゆうことじゃないって！
I said it's not like that (lit: it's not that type of thing)!

Trying or attempting something

Let's try some stuff

In English, we use the word, "try" to mean both "to try something out" and "to make an effort to do something". In Japanese, these are separate grammatical expressions. For instance, "I tried the cherry flavor" and "I tried to do homework" mean quite different things and though English does not make a distinction, Japanese does.

To try something out

Vocabulary

1. 見る 【み・る】 - to see; to watch
2. 切る 【き・る】 (u-verb) - to cut
3. お好み焼き 【お・この・み・や・き】 - okonomiyaki (Japanese-style pancake)
4. 初めて 【はじ・めて】 - for the first time
5. 食べる 【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
6. とても - very
7. おいしい (i-adj) - tasty
8. お酒 【お・さけ】 - alcohol
9. 飲む 【の・む】 (u-verb) - to drink
10. すごい (i-adj) - to a great extent
11. 眠い 【ねむ・い】 (i-adj) - sleepy
12. なる (u-verb) - to become
13. 新しい 【あた・らしい】 (i-adj) - new
14. デパート - department store
15. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
16. 広島 【ひろ・しま】 - Hiroshima

To try something out, you simply need to change the verb to the te-form and add 「みる」. If it helps you to remember, you can think of it as a sequence of an action and then seeing the result. In fact 「みる」 conjugates just like 「見る」. However, just like the 「～てほしい」 grammar we learned, this is a set phrase and 「みる」 is usually written in hiragana.

To try something out

Conjugate the verb to the te-form and add 「みる」.

Example: 切る → 切って → 切ってみる

You can treat the whole result as a regular verb just as you would with 「見る」.

Example: 切ってみる、切ってみた、切ってみない、切ってみなかった

Examples

1. お好み焼きを初めて食べてみたけど、とてもおいしかった！
I tried eating okonomiyaki for the first time and it was very tasty!
2. お酒を飲んでみましたが、すごく眠くなりました。
I tried drinking alcohol and I became extremely sleepy.
3. 新しいデパートに行ってみる。

I'm going to check out the new department store.

4. 広島のお好み焼きを食べてみたい！

I want to try eating Hiroshima okonomiyaki!

To attempt to do something

Vocabulary

1. する (exception) - to do
2. 言う 【い・う】 (u-verb) - to say
3. 思う 【おも・う】 (u-verb) - to think
4. 考える 【かんが・える】 (ru-verb) - to think
5. 見る 【み・る】 (ru-verb) - to see
6. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
7. 毎日 【まい・にち】 - everyday
8. 勉強 【べん・きょう】 - study
9. 避ける 【さ・ける】 (ru-verb) - to avoid
10. 無理矢理 【む・り・や・り】 - forcibly
11. 部屋 【へ・や】 - room
12. 入る 【はい・る】 (u-verb) - to enter
13. 早い 【はや・い】 (i-adj) - fast; early
14. 寝る 【ね・る】 (ru-verb) - to sleep
15. 結局 【けっ・きょく】 - eventually
16. 徹夜 【てつ・や】 - staying up all night
17. お酒 【お・さけ】 - alcohol
18. 飲む 【の・む】 (u-verb) - to drink
19. 奥さん 【おく・さん】 - wife (polite)
20. 止める 【と・める】 (ru-verb) - to stop
21. なるべく - as much as possible
22. ジム - gym
23. 決める 【き・める】 (ru-verb) - to decide

We already learned that the volitional form was used to indicate a will to set out to do something. If you guessed that this next grammar for attempting to do something would involve the volitional form, you were right. To say that you tried (as in attempted) to do something, you need to conjugate the verb into the volitional, enclose it in a quotation (so that we can perform an action on the clause) and finally add the verb 「する」. Or put more simply, you just add 「とする」 to the volitional form of the verb. This is simply an extension of the quoted relative clause from the last section. Instead of saying the quote (言う) or treating it as a thought (思う、考える), we are simply doing it with 「する」.

Attempting a certain action

Change the verb to the volitional form and add 「とする」.

Examples

1. 見る → 見よう → 見ようとする
2. 行く → 行こう → 行こうとする

Examples

- 1. 毎日、勉強を避けようとする。
Everyday, she attempts to avoid study.
- 2. 無理矢理に部屋に入ろうとしている。
He is attempting to force his way into the room.
- 3. 早く寝ようとしたけど、結局は徹夜した。
I attempted to sleep early but ended up staying up all night.
- 4. お酒を飲もうとしたが、奥さんが止めた。
He tried to drink alcohol but his wife stopped him.

Though we use the verb 「する」 to say, "to do attempt", we can use different verbs to do other things with the attempt. For instance, we can use the verb 「決める」 to say, "decide to attempt to do [X]". Here are some examples of other actions carried out on the attempt.

- 1. 勉強をなるべく避けようと思った。
I thought I would attempt to avoid studying as much as possible.
- 2. 毎日ジムに行こうと決めた。
Decided to attempt to go to gym everyday.

Giving and Receiving

Japanese people like gifts

Vocabulary

1. お歳暮 【お・せい・ぼ】 - year-end presents
2. お中元 【お・ちゅう・げん】 - Bon festival gifts
3. あげる (ru-verb) - to give; to raise
4. くれる (ru-verb) - to give
5. もらう (u-verb) - to receive

One thing about Japanese culture is that they're big on giving gifts. There are many different customs involving giving and receiving gifts (お歳暮、お中元、etc.) and when Japanese people go traveling, you can be sure that they're going to be picking up souvenirs to take back as gifts. Even when attending marriages or funerals, people are expected to give a certain amount of money as a gift to help fund the ceremony. You can see why properly learning how to express the giving and receiving of favors and items is a very important and useful skill. For some reason, the proper use of 「あげる」、「くれる」、and 「もらう」 has always haunted people studying Japanese as being horribly complex and intractable. I hope to prove in this section that it is conceptually quite straightforward and simple.

When to use 「あげる」

Vocabulary

1. あげる (ru-verb) - to give; to raise
2. 私【わたし】 - me; myself; I
3. 友達【とも・だち】 - friend
4. プレゼント - present
5. これ - this
6. 先生【せん・せい】 - teacher
7. 車【くるま】 - car
8. 買う【か・う】 (u-verb) - to buy
9. 代わり【か・わり】 - substitute
10. 行く【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
11. 学生【がく・せい】 - student
12. 父【ちち】 - father
13. いい (i-adj) - good
14. こと - event, matter
15. 教える【おし・える】 (ru-verb) - to teach; to inform

「あげる」 is the Japanese word for "to give" seen from the speaker's point of view. You must use this verb when you are giving something or doing something for someone else.

Examples

1. 私が友達にプレゼントをあげた。
I gave present to friend.
2. これは先生にあげる。
I'll give this to teacher.

In order to express the giving of a favor (verb) you must use the ever useful te-form and then attach 「あげる」. This applies to all the other sections in this lesson as well.

1. 車を買ってあげるよ。
I'll give you the favor of buying a car.
2. 代わりに行ってあげる。
I'll give you the favor of going in your place.

For third-person, this verb is used when the speaker is looking at it from the giver's point of view. We'll see the significance of this when we examine the verb 「くれる」 next.

1. 学生がこれを先生にあげる。
The student give this to teacher. (looking at it from the student's point of view)
2. 友達が父にいいことを教えてあげた。
Friend gave the favor of teaching something good to my dad. (looking at it from the friend's point

of view)

Using 「やる」 to mean 「あげる」

Vocabulary

1. 犬 【いぬ】 - dog
2. 餌 【えさ】 - food for animals
3. やる (u-verb) - to do

Usually used for pets, animals, and such, you can substitute 「やる」, which normally means "to do", for 「あげる」. You shouldn't use this type of 「やる」 for people because it is used when looking down on someone and can be offensive.

- 犬に餌をやった？

Did you give the dog food?

Here, 「やる」 does not mean "to do" but "to give". You can tell because "doing food to dog" doesn't make any sense.

When to use 「くれる」

Vocabulary

1. くれる (ru-verb) - to give
2. 友達【とも・だち】 - friend
3. 私【わたし】 - me; myself; I
4. プレゼント - present
5. これ - this
6. 先生【せん・せい】 - teacher
7. 車【くるま】 - car
8. 買う【か・う】 (u-verb) - to buy
9. 代わり【か・わり】 - substitute
10. 行く【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
11. 学生【がく・せい】 - student
12. 父【ちち】 - father
13. いい (i-adj) - good
14. こと - event, matter
15. 教える【おし・える】 (ru-verb) - to teach; to inform
16. あげる (ru-verb) - to give; to raise
17. 全部【ぜん・ぶ】 - everything
18. 食べる【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat

「くれる」 is also a verb meaning "to give" but unlike 「あげる」, it is from the receiver's point of view. You must use this verb when someone *else* is giving something or doing something for you (effectively the opposite of 「あげる」).

Examples

1. 友達が私にプレゼントをくれた。
Friend gave present to me.
2. これは、先生がくれた。
Teacher gave this to me.
3. 車を買ってくれるの？
You'll give me the favor of buying a car for me?
4. 代わりに行ってくれる？
Will you give me the favor of going in my place?

Similarly, when used in the third-person, the speaker is speaking from the receiver's point of view and not the giver.

1. 先生がこれを学生にくれる。
The teacher give this to student. (looking at it from the student's point of view)
2. 友達が父にいいことを教えてくれた。
Friend gave favor of teaching something good to my dad. (looking at it from the dad's point of view)

view)

The following diagram illustrates the direction of giving from the point of view of the speaker.



From the speaker's point of view, all the giving done to others "go up" to everybody else while the giving done by everybody else "goes down" to the speaker. This is probably related to the fact that there is an identical verb 「上げる」 meaning "to raise" that contains the character for "above" (上) and that the honorific version of 「くれる」 is 「下さる」 with the character for down (下). This restriction allows us to make certain deductions from vague sentences like the following:

- 先生が教えてあげるんですか。

Teacher, will you be the one to give favor of teaching to... [anybody other than the speaker]?

Because all giving done to the speaker must always use 「くれる」, we know that the teacher must be doing it for someone else and *not the speaker*. The speaker is also looking at it from the teacher's point of view as doing a favor for someone else.

- 先生が教えてくれるんですか。

Teacher, will you be the one to give favor of teaching to... [anybody including the speaker]?

Because the giver is not the speaker, the teacher is either giving to the speaker or anyone else. The speaker is viewing it from the receiver's point of view as receiving a favor done by the teacher.

Let's see some mistakes to watch out for.

- 私が全部食べてくれました。

「くれる」 is being used as giving done by the speaker. (Wrong)

- 私が全部食べてあげました。

I gave favor of eating it all. (Correct)

- 友達がプレゼントを私にあげた。

「あげる」 is being used as giving to the speaker. (Wrong)

- 友達がプレゼントを私にくれた。 - Friend gave present to me. (Correct)

When to use 「もらう」

Vocabulary

1. 私【わたし】 - me; myself; I
2. 友達【とも・だち】 - friend
3. プレゼント - present
4. もらう (u-verb) - to receive
5. これ - this
6. 買う【か・う】 (u-verb) - to buy
7. 宿題【しゅく・だい】 - homework
8. チェック - check
9. する (exception) - to do
10. 時間【じ・かん】 - time
11. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
12. 無理【む・り】 - impossible
13. その - that (abbr. of それの)
14. 時計【と・けい】 - watch; clock

「もらう」 meaning, "to receive" has only one version unlike 「あげる / くれる」 so there's very little to explain. One thing to point out is that since you receive *from* someone, 「から」 is also appropriate in addition to the 「に」 target particle.

Examples

1. 私が友達にプレゼントをもらった。
I received present from friend.
2. 友達からプレゼントをもらった。
I received present from friend.
3. これは友達に買ってもらった。
About this, received the favor of buying it from friend.
4. 宿題をチェックしてもらいたかったけど、時間がなくて無理だった。
I wanted to receive the favor of checking homework but there was no time and it was impossible.

「もらう」 is seen from the perspective of the receiver, so in the case of first-person, others usually don't receive things from you. However, you might want to use 「私からもらう」 when you want to emphasize that fact that the other person received it from you. For instance, if you wanted to say, "Hey, I gave you that!" you would use 「あげる」. However, you would use 「もらう」 if you wanted to say, "Hey, you got that from me!"

- その時計は私からもらったのよ。
(He) received that watch from me.

Asking favors with 「くれる」 or 「もらえる」

Vocabulary

1. 千円 【せん・ えん】 - 1,000 yen
2. 貸す 【か・ す】 (u-verb) - lend
3. する (exception) - to do
4. くれる (ru-verb) - to give
5. もらう (u-verb) - to receive
6. あなた - you
7. 私 【わたし】 - me; myself; I
8. ちょっと - a little
9. 静か 【しず・ か】 (na-adj) - quiet
10. 漢字 【かん・ じ】 - Kanji
11. 書く 【か・ く】 (u-verb) - to write

You can make requests by using 「くれる」 and the potential form of 「もらう」 (can I receive the favor of...). We've already seen an example of this in example 4 of the 「くれる」 section. Because requests are favors done for the speaker, you cannot use 「あげる」 in this situation.

Examples

1. 千円を貸してくれる？
Will you give me the favor of lending 1000 yen?
2. 千円を貸してもらえる？
Can I receive the favor of you lending 1000 yen?

Notice that the two sentences essentially mean the same thing. This is because the giver and receiver has been omitted because it is obvious from the context. If we were to write out the full sentence, it would look like this:

1. あなたが、私に 千円を貸してくれる？
Will you give me the favor of lending 1000 yen?
2. 私が、あなたに 千円を貸してもらえる？
Can I receive the favor of you lending 1000 yen?

It is not normal to explicitly include the subject and target like this when directly addressing someone but is provided here to illustrate the change of subject and target depending on the verb 「くれる」 and 「もらえる」.

You can use the negative to make the request a little softer. You'll see that this is true in many other types of grammar.

1. ちょっと静かにしてくれない？
Won't you be a little quieter?

2. 漢字で書いてもらえませんか。
Can you write this in kanji for me?

Asking someone to not do something

Vocabulary

1. 全部【ぜん・ぶ】 - everything
2. 食べる【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
3. くれる (ru-verb) - to give
4. 高い【たか・い】 (i-adj) - high; tall; expensive
5. 物【もの】 - object
6. 買う【か・う】 (u-verb) - to buy

In order to request that someone *not* do something, you simply attach 「で」 to the negative form of the verb and proceed as before.

1. 全部食べないでくれますか。
Can you not eat it all?
2. 高い物を買わないでくれる？
Can you not buy expensive thing(s)?

Making Requests

Politely (and not so politely) making requests

Similar to asking for favors, which we learned in the last lesson, there are also various ways to make requests in Japanese. This is effectively the Japanese way of saying, "please do X". We'll first learn the most common way to make requests using a special conjugation of the verb 「くださる」 and the firmer 「なさる」. Finally, we'll learn the rarely used excessively strong command form for the sake of completeness. You can safely skip the last part unless you're an avid reader of manga.

「～ください」 - a special conjugation of 「くださる」

Vocabulary

1. それ - that
2. くれる (ru-verb) - to give
3. 漢字 【かん・じ】 - Kanji
4. 書く 【か・く】 (u-verb) - to write
5. ここ - here
6. 来る 【く・る】 (exception) - to come
7. 日本語 【に・ほん・ご】 - Japanese (language)
8. 話す 【はな・す】 (u-verb) - to speak
9. 消しゴム 【け・し・ごむ】 - eraser
10. 貸す 【か・す】 (u-verb) - lend
11. 遠い 【とお・い】 (i-adj) - far
12. 所 【ところ】 - place
13. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
14. お父さん 【お・とう・さん】 - father (polite)
15. 時計 【と・けい】 - watch; clock
16. 壊れる 【こわ・れる】 (ru-verb) - to break
17. 言う 【い・う】 (u-verb) - to say

「ください」 is a special conjugation of 「くださる」, which is the honorific form of 「くれる」. We will learn more about honorific and humble forms in the beginning of the next major section. We are going over 「ください」 here because it has a slight difference in meaning from the normal 「くれる」 and the honorific 「くださる」. 「ください」 is different from 「くれる」 in the following fashion:

1. それをください。
Please give me that.
2. それをくれる？
Can you give me that?

As you can see 「ください」 is a direct request for something while 「くれる」 is used as a question asking for someone to give something. However, it is similar to 「くれる」 in that you can make a request for an action by simply attaching it to the te-form of the verb.

1. 漢字で書いてください。
Please write it in kanji.
2. ゆっくり話してください。
Please speak slowly.

The rules for negative requests are same as the rules for 「くれる」 as well.

1. 落書きを書かないでください。

Please don't write graffiti.

- ここにこないでください。

Please don't come here.

In casual speech, it is often common to simply drop the 「ください」 part.

- 日本語で話して。

Please speak in Japanese.

- 消しゴムを貸して。

Please lend me the eraser.

- 遠い所に行かないで。

Please don't go to a far place.

For those who want to sound particularly commanding and manly, it is also possible to use 「くれる」 with the 「る」 removed.

- 日本語で話してくれ。

Speak in Japanese.

- 消しゴムを貸してくれ。

Lend me the eraser.

- 遠い所に行かないでくれ。

Don't go to a far place.

Because 「ください」 like the masu-form must always come at the end sentence or a relative clause, you cannot use it to directly modify a noun. For example, the following is not possible with 「ください」.

- お父さんがくれた時計が壊れた。

The clock that father gave broke.

Of course, since direct quotes is merely repeating something someone said in verbatim, you can put practically anything in a direct quote.

- 「それをください」とお父さんが言った。

Father said, "Please give me that."

Using 「～ ちょうだい」 as a casual request

Vocabulary

1. 頂戴 【ちょうだい】 - receiving (humble)
2. 致す 【いたす】 (u-verb) - to do (humble)
3. スプーン - spoon
4. ここ - here
5. 名前 【な・ まえ】 - name
6. 書く 【か・ く】 (u-verb) - to write

A casual alternative of 「ください」 is 「ちょうだい」. While it can be used by anyone, it has a slightly feminine and childish nuance and is always written in Hiragana. Written in Kanji, it is usually used in a very formal expression such as 「頂戴致します」. Grammatically, it's used exactly the same way as 「ください」.

Examples

1. スプーンをちょうだい。
Please give me the spoon.
2. ここに名前を書いてちょうだい。
Please write your name here.

Using 「～なさい」 to make firm but polite requests

Vocabulary

1. 食べる 【たべ・る】 (ru-verb) - to eat
2. 飲む 【の・む】 (u-verb) - to drink
3. する (exception) - to do
4. いい (i-adj) - good
5. 聞く 【き・く】 (u-verb) - to ask; to listen
6. ここ - here
7. 座る 【すわ・る】 (ru-verb) - to sit
8. まだ - yet
9. いっぱい - full
10. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
11. たくさん - a lot (amount)
12. それ - that
13. 思う 【おも・う】 (u-verb) - to think
14. そう - (things are) that way

「なさい」 is a special honorific conjugation of 「する」. It is a soft yet firm way of issuing a command. It is used, for example, when a mother is scolding her child or when a teacher wants a delinquent student to pay attention. Unlike 「ください」, 「なさい」 only applies to positive verbs and uses the stem of the verb instead of the te-form. It also cannot be used by itself but must be attached to another verb.

Using 「なさい」 to make firm but polite requests

Conjugate the verb to its stem and attach 「なさい」

Examples

1. 食べる → 食べなさい
2. 飲む → 飲み → 飲みなさい
3. する → し → しなさい

Examples

1. よく聞きなさい！
Listen well!
2. ここに座りなさい。
Sit here.

You can also drop 「さい」 portion of the 「なさい」 to make a casual version of this grammar.

1. まだいっぱいあるから、たくさん食べな。

There's still a lot, so eat a lot.

2. それでいいと思うなら、そうしなよ。

If you think that's fine, then go ahead and do it.

The Command Form

Vocabulary

1. くれる (ru-verb) - to give
2. 死ぬ【し・ぬ】 (u-verb) - to die
3. する (exception) - to do
4. 来る【く・る】 (exception) - to come
5. 食べる【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
6. 着る【き・る】 (ru-verb) - to wear
7. 信じる【しん・じる】 (ru-verb) - to believe
8. 寝る【ね・る】 (ru-verb) - to sleep
9. 起きる【お・きる】 (ru-verb) - to wake; to occur
10. 出る【で・る】 (ru-verb) - to come out
11. 掛ける【か・ける】 (ru-verb) - to hang
12. 捨てる【す・てる】 (ru-verb) - to throw away
13. 話す【はな・す】 (u-verb) - to speak
14. 聞く【き・く】 (u-verb) - to ask; to listen
15. 遊ぶ【あそ・ぶ】 (u-verb) - to play
16. 待つ【ま・つ】 (u-verb) - to wait
17. 飲む【の・む】 (u-verb) - to drink
18. 直る【なお・る】 (u-verb) - to be fixed
19. 買う【か・う】 (u-verb) - to buy
20. 好き【す・き】 (na-adj) - likable
21. あっち - that way (over there) (abbr of あちら)
22. 行く【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
23. 早い【はや・い】 (i-adj) - fast; early
24. 酒【さけ】 - alcohol
25. 持つ【も・つ】 (u-verb) - to hold

We will go over the command form in the interest of covering all the possible verb conjugations. In reality, the command form is rarely used as Japanese people tend to be too polite to use imperatives. Also, this coarse type of speech is rarely, if indeed at all, used by females who tend to use 「なさい」 or an exasperated 「くれる」 when angry or irritated. This form is only really useful for reading or watching fictional works. You may often see or hear 「死ぬ！」 ("Die!") in fiction which, of course, you'll never hear in real life. (I hope!)

Be sure to note that, in addition to the familiar 「する」, 「くる」 exception verbs, 「くれる」 is also an exception for the command form.

Rules for creating command form

- For ru-verbs: Replace the 「る」 with 「ろ」

- **For u-verbs:** Change the last character from an / u / vowel to an / e / vowel
- **Exceptions:**
 1. する → しろ
 2. くる → こい
 3. くれる → くれ

Sample ru-verbs

Plain	Command
食べ <u>る</u>	食べ <u>ろ</u>
着 <u>る</u>	着 <u>ろ</u>
信じ <u>る</u>	信じ <u>ろ</u>
寝 <u>る</u>	寝 <u>ろ</u>
起き <u>る</u>	起き <u>ろ</u>
出 <u>る</u>	出 <u>ろ</u>
掛け <u>る</u>	掛け <u>ろ</u>
捨て <u>る</u>	捨て <u>ろ</u>

Sample u-verbs

Plain	Command
話 <u>す</u>	話 <u>せ</u>
聞 <u>く</u>	聞 <u>け</u>
遊 <u>ぶ</u>	遊 <u>べ</u>
待 <u>っ</u>	待 <u>て</u>
飲 <u>む</u>	飲 <u>め</u>
直 <u>る</u>	直 <u>れ</u>
死 <u>ぬ</u>	死 <u>ね</u>
買 <u>う</u>	買 <u>え</u>

Exception Verbs

Plain	Command
する	しろ
くる	こい
くれる	くれ

Examples

1. 好きにしろ。
Do as you please.
2. あっち行け！
Go away!
3. 早く酒を持ってきてくれ。
Hurry up and bring me some alcohol.

Negative Command

Vocabulary

1. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
2. する (exception) - to do
3. それ - that
4. 食べる 【た・べる】 (ru-verb) - to eat
5. 変 【へん】 (na-adj) - strange
6. こと - event, matter
7. 言う 【い・う】 (u-verb) - to say

The negative command form is very simple: simply attach 「な」 to either ru-verbs or u-verbs. Don't confuse this with the 「な」 sentence-ending particle we will be learning at the end of this section. The intonation is totally different.

Using the negative command form

Attach 「な」 to the verb

Examples

1. 行く → 行くな
2. する → するな

Examples

1. それを食べるな！
Don't eat that!
2. 変なことを言うな！
Don't say such weird things!

This is not to be confused with the shortened version of 「～なさい」 we just learned in the last section. The most obvious difference (besides the clear difference in tone) is that in 「～なさい」, the verb is first converted to the stem while the negative command has no conjugation. For example, for 「する」, 「しな」 would be the short version of 「しなさい」 while 「するな」 would be a negative command.

Numbers and Counting

Numbers and counting in Japanese are difficult enough to require its own section. First of all, the number system is in units of four instead of three, which can make converting into English quite difficult. Also, there are things called counters, which are required to count different types of objects, animals, or people. We will learn the most generic and widely used counters to get you started so that you can learn more on your own. To be honest, counters might be the only thing that'll make you want to quit learning Japanese, it's that bad. I recommend you digest only a little bit of this section at a time because it's an awful lot of things to memorize.

The Number System

The Japanese number system is spread into units of four. So a number such as 10,000,000 is actually split up as 1000,0000. However, thanks to the strong influence of the Western world and the standardization of numbers, when numbers are actually written, the split-off is three digits. Here are the first ten numbers.

Kanji and readings for numbers 1 to 10

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
一	二	三	四	五	六	七	八	九	十
いち	に	さん	し / よん	ご	ろく	しち / なな	はち	きゅう	じゅう

As the chart indicates, 4 can either be 「し」 or 「よん」 and 7 can either be 「しち」 or 「なな」. Basically, both are acceptable up to 10. However, past ten, the reading is almost always 「よん」 and 「なな」. In general, 「よん」 and 「なな」 are preferred over 「し」 and 「しち」 in most circumstances.

You can simply count from 1 to 99 with just these ten numbers. Japanese is easier than English in this respect because you do not have to memorize separate words such as "twenty" or "fifty". In Japanese, it's simply just "two ten" and "five ten".

- 1. 三十一 (さんじゅういち) = 31
- 2. 五十四 (ごじゅうよん) = 54
- 3. 七十七 (ななじゅうなな) = 77
- 4. 二十 (にじゅう) = 20

Notice that numbers are either always written in kanji or numerals because hiragana can get rather long and hard to decipher.

Numbers past 99

Here are the higher numbers:

Numerals	100	1,000	10,000	10^8	10^12
漢字	百	千	万	億	兆
ひらがな	ひゃく	せん	まん	おく	ちょう

Notice how the numbers jumped four digits from 10^4 to 10^8 between 万 and 億? That's because Japanese is divided into units of four. Once you get past 1万 (10,000), you start all over until you reach 9,999万, then it rotates to 1億 (100,000,000). By the way, 百 is 100 and 千 is 1,000, but anything past that, and you need to attach a 1 so the rest of the units become 一万 (10^4)、一億 (10^8)、一兆 (10^12).

Now you can count up to 9,999,999,999,999,999 just by chaining the numbers same as before. This is

where the problems start, however. Try saying 「いちちょう」、「ろくひゃく」、or 「さんせん」 really quickly, you'll notice it's difficult because of the repetition of similar consonant sounds. Therefore, Japanese people have decided to make it easier on themselves by pronouncing them as 「いっちょう」、「ろっぴゃく」、and 「さんぜん」. Unfortunately, it makes it all the harder for you to remember how to pronounce everything. Here are all the slight sound changes.

Numerals	漢字	ひらがな
300	三百	さんびゃく
600	六百	ろっぴゃく
800	八百	はっぴゃく
3000	三千	さんぜん
8000	八千	はっせん
10 ¹²	一兆	いっちょう

1. 四万三千七十六（よんまんさんぜんななじゅうろく）43,076
2. 七億六千二百四十九万九千二百二十二（ななおくろっぴゃくにじゅうよんまんきゅうせんにひゃくにじゅうに）706,249,222
3. 五百兆二万（ごひゃくちょうにまんいち）500,000,000,020,001

Notice that it is customary to write large numbers only in numerals as even kanji can become difficult to decipher.

Numbers smaller or less than 1

Vocabulary

1. 零【れい】 - zero
2. ゼロ - zero
3. マル - circle; zero
4. 点【てん】 - period; point
5. マイナス - minus

Zero in Japanese is 「零」 but 「ゼロ」 or 「マル」 is more common in modern Japanese. There is no special method for reading decimals, you simply say 「点」 for the dot and read each individual number after the decimal point. Here's an example:

- 0.0021 = ゼロ、点、ゼロ、ゼロ、二、一。

For negative numbers, everything is the same as positive numbers except that you say 「マイナス」 first.

- マイナス二十九 = -29

Counting and Counters

Ah, and now we come to the fun part. In Japanese, when you are simply counting numbers, everything is just as you would expect, 一、二、三、 and so on. However, if you want to count any type of object, you have to use something called a counter which depends on what type of object you are counting and on top of this, there are various sound changes similar to the ones we saw with 六百, etc.. The counter themselves are usually single kanji characters that often have a special reading just for the counter. First, let's learn the counters for dates

Dates

Vocabulary

- 1. 平成 【へい・せい】 - Heisei era
- 2. 昭和 【しょう・わ】 - Showa era
- 3. 和暦 【わ・れき】 - Japanese calendar
- 4. 一日 【いち・にち】 - one day

The year is very easy. All you have to do is say the number and add 「年」 which is pronounced here as 「ねん」. For example, Year 2003 becomes 2003年 (にせんさんねん). The catch is that there is another calendar which starts over every time a new emperor ascends the throne. The year is preceded by the era, for example the year 2000 is: 平成12年. My birthday, 1981 is 昭和56年 (The Showa era lasted from 1926 to 1989). You may think that you don't need to know this but if you're going to be filling out forms in Japan, they often ask you for your birthday or the current date in the Japanese calendar (和暦). So here's a [neat converter](#) you can use to convert to the Japanese calendar.

Saying the months is actually easier than English because all you have to do is write the number (either in numerals or kanji) of the month and add 「月」 which is read as 「がつ」. However, you need to pay attention to April (4月), July (7月), and September (9月) which are pronounced 「しがつ」、「しちがつ」、and 「くがつ」 respectively.

Finally, we get to the days of the month, which is where the headache starts. The first day of the month is 「ついたち」 (一日); *different* from 「いちにち」 (一日), which means "one day". Besides this and some other exceptions we'll soon cover, you can simply say the number and add 「日」 which is pronounced here as 「にち」. For example, the 26th becomes 26日 (にじゅうろくにち). Pretty simple, *however*, the first 10 days, the 14th, 19th, 20th, 29th have special readings that you must separately memorize. If you like memorizing things, you'll have a ball here. Notice that the kanji doesn't change but the reading does.

Days of the month

Day	Kanji	Reading
What day	何日	なん・にち
1st	一日	<u>ついたち</u>

2nd	二日	<u>ふつ・か</u>
3rd	三日	<u>みつ・か</u>
4th	四日	<u>よつ・か</u>
5th	五日	<u>いつ・か</u>
6th	六日	<u>むい・か</u>
7th	七日	<u>なの・か</u>
8th	八日	<u>よう・か</u>
9th	九日	<u>ここの・か</u>
10th	十日	<u>とお・か</u>
11th	十一日	じゅう・いち・にち
12th	十二日	じゅう・に・にち
13th	十三日	じゅう・さん・にち
14th	十四日	<u>じゅう・よつ・か</u>
15th	十五日	じゅう・ご・にち
16th	十六日	じゅう・ろく・にち
17th	十七日	<u>じゅう・しち・にち</u>
18th	十八日	じゅう・はち・にち
19th	十九日	<u>じゅう・く・にち</u>
20th	二十日	<u>はつ・か</u>
21st	二十一日	に・じゅう・いち・にち
22nd	二十二日	に・じゅう・に・にち
23rd	二十三日	に・じゅう・さん・にち
24th	二十四日	<u>に・じゅう・よつ・か</u>
25th	二十五日	に・じゅう・ご・にち
26th	二十六日	に・じゅう・ろく・にち
27th	二十七日	<u>に・じゅう・しち・にち</u>
28th	二十八日	に・じゅう・はち・にち
29th	二十九日	<u>に・じゅう・く・にち</u>
30th	三十日	さん・じゅう・にち
31st	三十一日	さん・じゅう・いち・にち

In Japan, the full format for dates follows the international date format and looks like: XXXX年YY月ZZ日. For example, today's date would be: 2003年12月 2日

Time

Now, we'll learn how to tell time. The hour is given by saying the number and adding 「時」 which

is pronounced here as 「じ」. Here is a chart of exceptions to look out for.

英語	4 o'clock	7 o'clock	9 o'clock
漢字	四時	七時	九時
ひらがな	よじ	しちじ	くじ

Notice how the numbers 4, 7, and 9 keep coming up to be a pain in the butt? Well, those and sometimes 1, 6 and 8 are the numbers to watch out for. The minutes are given by adding 「分」 which usually read as 「ぶん」 with the following exceptions:

英語	1 min	3 min	4 min	6 min	8 min	10 min
漢字	一分	三分	四分	六分	八分	十分
ひらがな	いっぶん	さんぶん	よんぶん	ろっぶん	はっぶん	じゅっぶん

For higher number, you use the normal pronunciation for the higher digits and rotate around the same readings for 1 to 10. For instance, 24 minutes is 「にじゅうよんぶん」 (二十四分) while 30 minutes is 「さんじゅっぶん」 (三十分). There are also other less common but still correct pronunciations such as 「はちぶん」 for 「八分」 and 「じっぶん」 for 「十分」 (this one is almost never used).

All readings for seconds consists of the number plus 「秒」, which is read as 「びょう」. There are no exceptions for seconds and all the readings are the same.

Some examples of time.

1. 1時24分 (いちじ・ にじゅうよんぶん) 1:24
2. 午後4時10分 (ごご・ よじ・ じゅっぶん) 4:10 PM
3. 午前9時16分 (ごぜん・ くじ・ じゅうろっぶん) 9:16 AM
4. 13時16分 (じゅうさんじ・ じゅうろっぶん) 13:16
5. 2時18分13秒 (にじ・ じゅうはっぶん・ じゅうさんびょう) 2:18:13

A Span of Time

Ha! I bet you thought you were done with dates and time, well guess again. This time we will learn counters for counting spans of time, days, months, and years. The basic counter for a span of time is 「間」, which is read as 「かん」. You can attach it to the end of hours, days, weeks, and years. Minutes (in general) and seconds do not need this counter and months have a separate counter, which we will cover next.

1. 二時間四十分 (にじかん・ よんじゅっぶん) 2 hours and 40 minutes
2. 二十日間 (はつかかん) 20 days
3. 十五日間 (じゅうごにちかん) 15 days
4. 二年間 (にねんかん) two years
5. 三週間 (さんしゅうかん) three weeks
6. 一日 (いちにち) 1 day

As mentioned before, a period of one day is 「一日」 (いちにち) which is different from the 1st of the month: 「ついたち」.

Pronunciations to watch out for when counting weeks is one week: 「一週間」 (いっしゅうかん) and 8 weeks: 「八週間」 (はっしゅうかん).

To count the number of months, you simple take a regular number and add 「か」 and 「月」 which is pronounced here as 「げつ」 and *not* 「がつ」. The 「か」 used in this counter is usually written as a small katakana 「ケ」 which is confusing because it's still pronounced as 「か」 and not 「け」. The small 「ケ」 is actually totally different from the katakana 「ケ」 and is really an abbreviation for the kanji 「箇」, the original kanji for the counter. This small 「ケ」 is also used in some place names such as 「千駄ケ谷」 and other counters, such as the counter for location described in the "Other Counters" section below.

In counting months, you should watch out for the following sound changes:

英語	1 month	6 months	10 months
漢字	一ヶ月	六ヶ月	十ヶ月
ひらがな	いっかげつ	ろっかげつ	じゅっかげつ

Just like minutes, the high numbers rotate back using the same sounds for 1 to 10.

- 1. 十一ヶ月 (じゅういっかげつ) Eleven months
- 2. 二十ヶ月 (にじゅっかげつ) Twenty months
- 3. 三十三ヶ月 (さんじゅうさんかげつ) Thirty three months

Other Counters

We'll cover some of the most common counters so that you'll be familiar with how counters work. This will hopefully allow you to learn other counters on your own because there are too many to even consider covering them all. The important thing to remember is that using the wrong counter is grammatically incorrect. If you are counting people, you **must** use the people counter, etc. Sometimes, it is acceptable to use a more generic counter when a less commonly used counter applies. Here are some counters.

日本語	When to Use
人	To count the number of people
本	To count long, cylindrical objects such as bottles or chopsticks
枚	To count thin objects such as paper or shirts
冊	To count bound objects usually books
匹	To count small animals like cats or dogs
歳	To count the age of a living creatures such as people
個	To count small (often round) objects

回	To count number of times
ヶ所 (箇所)	To count number of locations
つ	To count any generic object that has a rare or no counter

Counting 1 to 10 (some variations might exist)

	人	本	枚	冊	匹	歳	個	回	ヶ所 (箇所)	つ
1	<u>ひとり</u>	<u>いっぽん</u>	いちまい	<u>いっさつ</u>	<u>いっぴき</u>	<u>いっさい</u>	<u>いっこ</u>	<u>いっかい</u>	<u>いっかしょ</u>	<u>ひとつ</u>
2	<u>ふたり</u>	にほん	にまい	にさつ	にひき	にさい	にこ	にかい	にかしよ	<u>ふたつ</u>
3	さんにん	<u>さんぽん</u>	さんまい	さんさつ	<u>さんびき</u>	さんさい	さんこ	さんかい	さんかしよ	<u>みつ</u>
4	<u>よにん</u>	よんほん	よんまい	よんさつ	よんひき	よんさい	よんこ	よんかい	よんかしよ	<u>よっつ</u>
5	ごにん	ごほん	ごまい	ごさつ	ごひき	ごさい	ごこ	ごかい	ごかしよ	<u>いっつ</u>
6	ろくにん	<u>ろっぽん</u>	ろくまい	ろくさつ	<u>ろっぴき</u>	ろくさい	<u>ろっこ</u>	<u>ろっかい</u>	<u>ろっかしよ</u>	<u>むっつ</u>
7	<u>しちにん</u>	ななほん	ななまい	ななさつ	ななひき	ななさい	ななこ	ななかい	ななかしよ	ななつ
8	はちにん	はちほん	はちまい	<u>はっさつ</u>	<u>はっぴき</u>	<u>はっさい</u>	<u>はっこ</u>	はちかい	<u>はっかしよ</u>	<u>やっつ</u>
9	きゅうにん	きゅうほん	きゅうまい	きゅうさつ	きゅうひき	きゅうさい	きゅうこ	きゅうかい	きゅうかしよ	<u>ここのつ</u>
10	じゅうにん	<u>じゅうぽん</u>	じゅうまい	<u>じゅうさつ</u>	<u>じゅうぴき</u>	<u>じゅうさい</u>	<u>じゅうこ</u>	<u>じゅうかい</u>	<u>じゅうかしよ</u>	<u>とお</u>

The changed sounds have been highlighted. You don't count 0 because there is nothing to count. You can simply use 「ない」 or 「いない」. The chart has hiragana for pronunciation but, as before, it is usually written with either numbers or kanji plus the counter with the single exception of 「とお」 which is simply written as 「十」.

For higher numbers, it's the same as before, you use the normal pronunciation for the higher digits and rotate around the same readings for 1 to 10 except for 「一人」 and 「二人」 which transforms to the normal 「いち」 and 「に」 once you get past the first two. So 「一人」 is 「ひとり」 while 「11人」 is 「じゅういちにん」. Also, the generic counter 「～つ」 only applies up to exactly ten items. Past that, you can just use regular plain numbers.

Note: The counter for age is often sometimes written as 「才」 for those who don't have the time to write out the more complex kanji. Plus, age 20 is usually read as 「はたち」 and not 「にじゅっさ

Using 「目」 to show order

You can attach 「目」 (read as 「め」) to various counters to indicate the order. The most common example is the 「番」 counter. For example, 「一番」 which means "number one" becomes "the first" when you add 「目」 (一番目). Similarly, 「一回目」 is the first time, 「二回目」 is the second time, 「四人目」 is the fourth person, and so on.

Casual Patterns and Slang

So far, for every grammar we have covered, we also went over all the casual variations as well. However, even though we have already covered all the casual forms, truly mastering casual speech in Japanese requires far more than just learning the various casual forms. There are countless numbers of ways in which wordings and pronunciations change as well as differences between male and female speech. Understanding slang also requires knowing various vocabulary that is also growing with every new generation. Many adults would be hard-pressed to understand the kind of slang being used by kids today.

While comprehensively covering slang and relevant vocabulary would require a book in and of itself (a book that would soon become out of date), I'll instead cover some broad patterns and common phenomenon which will at least help you get started in understanding the most common aspects of Japanese slang. There is no particular order in the material presented here and I expect this page to grow continuously as I find different things to cover.

Please note that slang is also heavily influenced by local dialects. Although all the material presented here is valid for the greater Tokyo area, your mileage may vary depending on where you are located.

Basic Principles of Slang

In the world of slang, anything goes and rules that apply to written Japanese are often broken. The most difficult part is that, of course, you can't just say whatever you want. When you break the rules, you have to break it the correct way. Taking what you learned from textbooks or Japanese classes and applying it to the real world is not so easy because it is impossible to teach all the possible ways things can get jumbled up in the spoken language. Learning how to speak naturally with all the correct idiosyncrasies and inconsistencies in a language is something that requires practice with real people in real-world situations. In this section, we'll look at some common patterns and themes that will at least help you get an idea of where the majority of slang originates from.

One thing you'll soon realize when you first start talking to Japanese people in real life is that many sounds are slurred together. This is especially true for males. The fact is voices in instructional material such as language tapes often exaggerate the pronunciation of each letter in order to make aural comprehension easier. In reality, not all the sounds are pronounced as clearly as it should be and things end up sounding different from how it's written on paper.

There is one major driving factor behind the majority of slang in Japanese. The primary goal of most slang is to make things easier to say. In other words, the goal is to reduce or simplify the movement of your mouth. There are two primary ways in which this is accomplished, 1) By making things shorter or, 2) By slurring the sounds together. We have already seen many examples of the first method such as shortening 「かもしれない」 to 「かも」 or preferring 「と」 to the longer conditional forms. The second method makes things easier to say usually by substituting parts of words with sounds that fit better with the sounds surrounding it or by merging two or more sounds together. For example, the same 「かもしれない」 might be pronounced 「かもしんない」 since 「しん」 requires less movement than 「しれ」.

The fundamental goal of slang is to reduce mouth movement

Let's see some more examples of words that get shortened or slurred. Try saying both versions to get a feel for how the slang saves space and some calories for your mouth.

Examples

Vocabulary

1. ここ - here
2. つまらない (i-adj) - boring
3. 私 【わたし】 - me; myself; I
4. 家 【1) うち; 2) いえ】 - 1) one's own home; 2) house
5. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
6. まったく - entirely; indeed; good grief (expression of exasperation)
7. いつ - when

- 8. こんな - this sort of
- 9. 所【ところ】 - place
- 10. ぐずぐず - tardily; hesitatingly
- 11. する (exception) - to do

- 1. ここはつまらないから私の家に行こう。
- 2. ここ つまらない から、私んち 行こう。

- 1. まったく、いつまでこんなところで、ぐずぐずするんだよ。
- 2. ったく、いつまでこんな とこ で、ぐずぐず すんだ よ。

You'll see that a great deal of slang in Japanese stems from this single principle of making things easier to say. It's very natural because it's guided by how your mouth moves. With a fair amount of practice, you should be able to naturally pick up shorter, alternative pronunciations and incorporate them into your own speech.

Sentence ordering and particles (or the lack thereof)

Vocabulary

1. それ - that
2. 何【なに / なん】 - what
3. 見る【み・る】 (ru-verb) - to see
4. あの - that (over there) (abbr. of あれの)
5. 人【ひと】 - person
6. もう - already
7. 食べる【たべ・る】 (ru-verb) - to eat
8. 昨日【きのう】 - yesterday
9. 買う【か・う】 (u-verb) - to buy
10. アイス - ice (short for ice cream)

While written Japanese already has fairly loose rules regarding sentence order, casual spoken Japanese takes it one step further. A complete sentence requires a verb at the end of the sentence to complete the thought. However, we'll see how this rule is bent in casual conversations.

Conversations are sporadic and chaotic in any language and it's common for people to say the first thing that pops into their head without thinking out the whole proper sentence.

For example, if you wanted to ask what something was, the normal, proper way would be to ask, 「それは何？」 However, if the first thing that popped into your head, "What the?" then it would be more natural to say 「何」 first. However, since 「何はそれ？」 doesn't make any sense (Is what that?), you can simply break it up into what are essentially two sentence fragments asking "what" first (何?), and then following it up with the explanation of what you were talking about (「それ」 in this case). For the sake of convenience, this is lumped into what looks like one sentence.

Examples

1. それは何？
What is that?
2. 何それ？
What? That. (Two sentences lumped into one)

Sometimes, the first thing that pops into your head might be main verb. But if the main verb has already slipped out of your mouth, you're now left with the rest of the sentence without a verb to complete the thought. In conversational Japanese, it's perfectly acceptable to have the verb come first using the same technique we just saw by breaking them into two sentences. The second sentence is incomplete of course, but that kind of thing is common in the speech of any language.

1. 見た？ あの人？
Did you see? That guy?
2. もう食べた？ 昨日買ったアイス。

You ate it already? The ice cream I bought yesterday.

Using 「じゃん」 instead of 「じゃない」 to confirm

Vocabulary

1. サラリーマン - office worker (salary man)
2. 残業【ざん・ぎょう】 - overtime
3. たくさん - a lot (amount)
4. する (exception) - to do
5. まあ - well
6. いい (i-adj) - good
7. ほら - look
8. やはり / やっぱり - as I thought
9. レポート - report
10. 書く【か・く】 (u-verb) - to write
11. 駄目【だめ】 - no good
12. 誰【だれ】 - who
13. いる (ru-verb) - to exist (animate)
14. ここ - here
15. 着替える【きが・える】 (ru-verb) - to change clothes
16. ～君【～くん】 - name suffix
17. 知る【し・る】 (u-verb) - to know
18. やはり / やっぱり / やっぱ - as I thought
19. 駅【えき】 - station
20. 近い【ちか・い】 (i-adj) - close, near
21. カラオケ - karaoke
22. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
23. うん - yes (casual)
24. あそこ - over there
25. すぐ - soon; nearby
26. 隣【となり】 - next to

「じゃん」 is an abbreviation of 「じゃない」, the negative conjugation for nouns and na-adjectives. However, this only applies to 「じゃない」 used in the following fashion.

- サラリーマンだから、残業はたくさんするんじゃない？

Because he's a salaryman, doesn't he do a lot of overtime?

The important thing to note about the example above is that 「じゃない」 here is actually confirming the positive. In fact, a closer translation is, “Because he's a salaryman, he *probably does* a lot of overtime.” But it's still a question so there's a slight nuance that you are seeking confirmation even though you are relatively sure.

「じゃん」 is a shorter slang for expressing the same type of thing except it doesn't even bother to ask a question to confirm. It's completely affirmative in tone.

In fact, the closest equivalent to 「じゃん」 is 「じゃない」 used in the following fashion.

- まあ、いいじゃない。

Well, it's probably fine (don't you think?).

This type of expression is the **only** case where you can attach 「じゃない」 directly to i-adjectives and verbs. Once you actually hear this expression in real life, you'll see that it has a distinct pronunciation that is different from simply using the negative. Plus, you have to realize that this type of 「じゃない」 sounds rather mature and feminine, unlike 「じゃん」, which is gender-neutral.

Like the above, specialized use of 「じゃない」, you can also attach 「じゃん」 directly to verbs and i-adjectives as well as the usual nouns and na-adjectives. Because slang is usually created to make things easier, it's not surprising that the rules for using 「じゃん」 are so lax and easy.

Summary

- Though derived from 「じゃない」, 「じゃん」 is always used to confirm the positive.
- It can be attached to the end of any sentence regardless of whether it ends in a noun, adjective, verb, or adverb.

Finally, let's get to the examples. Hopefully, you can see that 「じゃん」 is basically saying something along the lines of, "See, I'm right, aren't I?"

Examples

1. ほら、やっぱりレポートを書かないとだめじゃん。

See, as I thought, you have to write the report.

2. 誰もいないからここで着替えてもいいじゃん。

Since there's nobody, it's probably fine to change here.

A : たかし君は、ここにいる？

A: Is Takashi here?

B : 知らない。

B: Dunno.

A : あっ！やっぱ、いるじゃん！

A: Ah! See, he is here!

There's also another variation, which attaches the question marker as well. The meaning is mostly the same but it adds more to the questioning, confirming tone.

A : 駅の近くにカラオケがあるじゃんか。

A: There's a karaoke place near the station, right?

B : うん。

B: Yeah.

A : あそこのすぐ隣だ。

A: It's right next to there.

Using 「つ」 for 「という」

Vocabulary

1. 言う 【い・う】 (u-verb) - to say
2. 何で 【なん・で】 - why; how
3. お前 【お・まえ】 - you (casual)
4. ここ - here
5. いる (ru-verb) - to exist (animate)
6. 宿題 【しゅく・だい】 - homework
7. 時間 【じ・かん】 - time
8. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
9. デート - date
10. する (exception) - to do
11. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
12. 聞く 【き・く】 (u-verb) - to ask; to listen
13. 明日 【あした】 - tomorrow
14. 試験 【し・けん】 - exam
15. 勉強 【べん・きょう】 - study
16. 違う 【ちが・う】 (u-verb) - to be different

As we learned in the defining and describing section, 「いう」 serves many more functions than the equivalent English verb, "to say". It is used all the time and therefore, it's not too surprising that a number of variations and slang have developed. Here's one more that I felt was too "slangy" to cover so early at that point of the guide.

This may sound hard to believe but if you really slur 「という」 together, it becomes something resembling 「つ」. Or least, that's what somebody thought when he or she began replacing 「という」 with 「つ」 or in some case 「つう」.

Now, in my opinion, 「つ」 is a lot harder to say than 「という」 so using it like a native might take a bit of practice. Rather than making things easier to say, as is usually the case, the real purpose of this substitution is to sound rougher because 「つ」 has a harder, hissing sound. This is ideal for when you're pissed or for that young and rough image you've always wanted. As you might expect, this type of speech is usually used by males or very tough females.

Examples

1. **つうか**、なんでお前がここにいんのよ！
Or rather, why are you here?!
2. 宿題で時間がない**つって**んのに、みきちゃんとデートしにいったと聞いたよ。
Although he's saying he doesn't have time due to homework, I heard he went on a date with Miki-chan.
3. 明日は試験だぞ。**つっても**、勉強はしてないだろうな。
Yo, tomorrow's the test. Even if I say that, you probably didn't study anyway, huh?

4. だから、違うんだっうの！

Like I said, you're wrong!

If you want even more emphasis, you can even add a small 「つ」. This usually means you are really at the brink of your patience.

- だから、違うんだっつうの！

Like I said, you're wrong!

Using 「ってば」 and 「ったら」 to show exasperation

Vocabulary

1. もう - already
2. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
3. あなた - you
4. いつも - always
5. 忘れる 【わす・れる】 (ru-verb) - to forget

「ってば」 and 「ったら」 is yet another type of abbreviation for 「という」 similar to 「って」 as discussed in the defining and describing section. In this case, it's an abbreviation of the conditional form of 「という」, which is 「といえば」 and 「いったら」. By using this abbreviation, you are essentially saying something along the lines of, "If I told you once, I told you a million times!" You can use this expression when you're tired of repeating yourself or when you are exasperated with somebody for not listening to you.

Examples

1. もう行くってば！
I told you I'm going already!
2. あなたったら、いつも忘れるんだから。
You're always forgetting.

Using 「なんか」 just about everywhere

Vocabulary

1. 何【なに / なん】 - what
2. 食べる【たべ・る】 (ru-verb) - to eat
3. 今日【きょう】 - today
4. 忙しい【いそが・しい】 (i-adj) - busy
5. 風呂【ふ・ろ】 - bath
6. 超【ちょう】 - super
7. 気持ち【き・も・ち】 - feeling
8. いい (i-adj) - good
9. お母さん【お・かあ・さん】 - mother (polite)
10. 明日【あした】 - tomorrow
11. 戻る【もど・る】 (u-verb) - to return
12. 私【わたし】 - me; myself; I
13. こと - event, matter
14. 本当【ほん・とう】 - real
15. 好き【す・き】 (na-adj) - likable; desirable

By now, you're probably aware that 「何」 can be either read as 「なに」 or 「なん」 depending on what comes after it such as 「何色」 (なにいろ) versus 「何人」 (なんにん). In the case of 「何か」, while 「なにか」 is the correct reading, it is often contracted to just 「なんか」 in casual speech.

- なにか 食べる？
Eat something?
- なんか 食べる？
Eat something?

However, 「なんか」 also has a function similar to the word "like" in English. By "like", I'm not talking about the actual word but the kind that has no meaning and some people use just about anywhere in the sentence. Similarly, 「なんか」 can also be used as a filler without any actual meaning. For instance, take a look at the example below.

- 今日は、なんか 忙しいみたいよ。
I guess he's like busy today.

While 「なんか」 is a shorter version of 「なにか」, only 「なんか」 can be used in this way as a filler.

- 今日は、なにか 忙しいみたいよ。
(「なにか」 cannot be used as a filler word.)

Let's take a look at a few more examples.

Examples

1. なんかね。お風呂って超気持ちいいよね！
Like, baths feel really good, huh?
2. お母さんが、なんか明日まで戻らないんだってよ。
Mom said she's not coming back until like tomorrow.
3. なんかさ。ボブは、私のことなんか本当に好きかな？
-Hey like, do you really think that Bob likes somebody like me?

Showing contempt for an action with 「～やがる」

Vocabulary

1. あんな - that sort of
2. 奴【やつ】 - guy (derogatory)
3. 負ける【ま・ける】 (ru-verb) - to lose
4. どう - how
5. する (exception) - to do
6. やる (u-verb) - to do
7. 気【き】 - mood; intent
8. さっさと - quickly
9. 来る【く・る】 (exception) - to come

「やがる」 is a verb suffix used to indicate hatred or contempt for the person doing the action. Unlike the rest of the slang covered here, this extremely strong language is **not** used in normal, everyday conversations. You will probably never hear this expression outside of movies, comic books, games, and the like. However, it is covered here so that you can understand when it is used in those mediums.

In order to use 「やがる」, you simply attach it to the stem of the verb. After that, 「やがる」 is conjugated just like a regular u-verb.

Examples

1. あんなやつに負けやがって。じゃ、どうすんだよ？
Losing to a guy like that. Well, what are you going to do?
2. やる気か？だったらさっさと来やがれ！
You want to fight? If so, then hurry up and come on!

Review and more sentence-ending particles

We are coming to the end of the fourth major section of the guide. Do you feel like your Japanese has improved? We've come to the point where we've learned enough conjugations to be able to start mixing them together in various useful combinations. Of course this can be a little difficult to do without some practice, which is the reason for this lesson. But first, since we've come to the end of yet another section, let's learn some more sentence-endings particles.

「な」 and 「さ」 sentence-ending particles

Vocabulary

1. あのう / あの - say; well; errr
2. うん - yes (casual)
3. この - this (abbr. of これの)
4. 間【あいだ】 - space (between); time (between); period
5. ディズニーランド - Disney Land
6. 行く【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
7. すごい (i-adj) - to a great extent
8. 込む【こ・む】 (u-verb) - to become crowded
9. 何【なに / なん】 - what
10. 出来る【で・き・る】 (ru-verb) - to be able to do
11. 今【いま】 - now
12. 図書館【と・しょ・かん】 - library
13. 何で【なん・で】 - why; how
14. 日本語【に・ほん・ご】 - Japanese (language)
15. たくさん - a lot (amount)
16. 勉強【べん・きょう】 - study
17. する (exception) - to do
18. まだ - yet
19. 全然【ぜん・ぜん】 - not at all (when used with negative)
20. 分かる【わ・かる】 (u-verb) - to understand
21. 大丈夫【だい・じょう・ぶ】 (na-adj) - ok
22. なる (u-verb) - to become
23. いい (i-adj) - good
24. 今日【きょう】 - today
25. 雨【あめ】 - rain
26. 降る【ふ・る】 (u-verb) - to precipitate
27. 大学【だい・がく】 - college

After the 「よ」 and 「ね」, 「さ」 and 「な」 are the next most commonly used sentence-ending particles.

「さ」, which is basically a very casual form of 「よ」, is similar to the English "like" in that some people throw it in at the end of almost every single phrase. Of course, that doesn't mean it's necessarily a very sophisticated manner of speech but just like using "like" all the time, I cannot deny that it is an easy habit to fall into. In that sense, due to its over-use, it has almost lost any specific meaning. You may overhear a conversation like the following:

A : あのさ . . . A: Hey... B : うん。 B: Yeah. A : この間さ . . . A: This one time...
B : うん。 B: Yeah. A : ディズニーランドに行ったんだけどさ、なんかさ、すごい込
んで . . . A: I went to Disney Land and it was really crowded... B : うん B: Uh huh. A : 何
もできなくてさ . . . A: Couldn't do anything, you know... And it goes on like this, sometimes the

other person might break in to say something related to the topic.

You can use 「な」 in place of 「ね」 when it sounds too soft and reserved for what you want to say or for the audience you are speaking to. Its rough sound generally applies to the male gender but is not necessarily restricted to only males.

Example 1

洋介：今、図書館に行くんだよな。 Yousuke: You are going to the library now huh? (seeking explanation) 智子：うん、なんで？ Tomoko: Yeah, why?

Example 2

ボブ：日本語は、たくさん勉強したけどな。まだ全然わからない。 Bob: I studied Japanese a lot, right? But, I still don't get it at all. アリス：大丈夫よ。きっとわかるようになるからさ。 Alice: No problem. You'll become able to understand for sure, you know? ボブ：ならいいけどな。 Bob: If so, it would be good.

The 「な」 sentence-ending particle is often used with the question marker 「か」 to indicate that the speaker is considering something.

1. 今日は雨が降るかな？ I wonder if it'll rain today.
2. いい大学に行けるかな？ I wonder if I can go to a good college.

「かい」 and 「だい」 sentence-ending particles

Vocabulary

1. おい - hey
2. どこ - where
3. 行く 【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
4. 呼ぶ 【よ・ぶ】 (u-verb) - to call
5. いい (i-adj) - good
6. 一体 【いったい】 - forms an emphatic question (e.g. "why on earth?")
7. 何時 【なん・じ】 - what time
8. 帰る 【かえ・る】 (u-verb) - to go home
9. つもり - intention, plan
10. 俺 【おれ】 - me; myself; I (masculine)
11. 土曜日 【ど・よう・び】 - Saturday
12. 映画 【えい・が】 - movie
13. 見る 【み・る】 (ru-verb) - to see
14. 一緒 【いっ・しょ】 - together

「かい」 and 「だい」 are strongly masculine sentence endings for asking questions. 「かい」 is used for yes/no questions while 「だい」 is used for open-ended questions.

Examples

1. おい、どこに行くんだい? Hey, where are (you) going?
2. さきちゃんって呼んでもいいかい? Can (I) call you Saki-chan?
3. 一体何時に帰ってくるつもりだったんだい? What time were (you) planning on coming home exactly?
4. 俺は土曜日、映画を見に行くけど、一緒に行くかい? I'm going to see a movie Saturday, go together?

Gender-specific sentence-ending particles

These sentence-ending particles are primarily used just to emphasize something and doesn't really have a meaning per se. However, they can make your statements sound much stronger and/or very gender-specific. Using 「わ」 is just like 「よ」 except it will make you sound very feminine (this is a different sound from the 「わ」 used in Kansai dialect). 「かしら」 is also a very feminine version of 「かな」, which we just went over. 「ぞ」 and 「ぜ」 are identical to 「よ」 except that it makes you sound "cool" and manly, or at least, that is the intent. These examples may not be very helpful without actually hearing what they sound like.

Vocabulary

1. もう - already
2. 時間【じ・かん】 - time
3. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
4. おい - hey
5. 行く【い・く】 (u-verb) - to go
6. これ - this
7. 終わり【お・わり】 - end
8. いい (i-adj) - good
9. 大学【だい・がく】 - college
10. 入る【はい・る】 (u-verb) - to enter

1. もう時間がないわ。 There is no more time.
2. おい、行くぞ！ Hey, we're going!
3. これで、もう終わりだぜ。 With this, it's over already.
4. いい大学に入れるかしら？ I wonder if I can enter a good college.

That's a wrap!

Vocabulary

1. 加賀 【か・ が】 - Kaga (last name)
2. 先生 【せん・ せい】 - teacher
3. ちょっと - a little
4. 質問 【しつ・ もん】 - question
5. 聞く 【き・ く】 (u-verb) - to ask; to listen
6. いい (i-adj) - good
7. はい - yes (polite)
8. 日本語 【に・ ほん・ ご】 - Japanese (language)
9. 何 【なに / なん】 - what
10. 言う 【い・ う】 (u-verb) - to say
11. そう - (things are) that way
12. 大体 【だい・ たい】 - mostly
13. こんにちは - good day
14. 思う 【おも・ う】 (u-verb) - to think
15. ただし - however
16. 書く 【か・ く】 (u-verb) - to write
17. 時 【とき】 - time
18. 他 【ほか】 - other
19. 表現 【ひょう・ げん】 - expression
20. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
21. これ - this
22. 覚える 【おぼ・ える】 (ru-verb) - to memorize
23. 朝 【あさ】 - morning
24. おはよう - good morning
25. でも - but
26. 上 【うえ】 - above
27. 人 【ひと】 - person
28. おはようございます - good morning (polite)
29. 分かる 【わ・ かる】 (u-verb) - to understand
30. 間違える 【ま・ ちが・ える】 (ru-verb) - to make a mistake
31. 勉強 【べん・ きょう】 - study
32. なる (u-verb) - to become
33. 洋介 【よう・ すけ】 - Yousuke (first name)
34. あのう / あの - say; well; errr
35. 英語 【えい・ ご】 - English (language)
36. 教える 【おし・ える】 (ru-verb) - to teach; to inform
37. もらう (u-verb) - to receive
38. もし - if by any chance
39. 時間 【じ・ かん】 - time
40. うん - yes (casual)

41. アメリカ - America
42. 留学 【りゅう・ がく】 - study abroad
43. する (exception) - to do
44. 去年 【きょ・ ねん】 - last year
45. 行く 【い・ く】 (u-verb) - to go
46. お金 【お・ かね】 - money
47. ある (u-verb) - to exist (inanimate)
48. いつ - when
49. 欲しい 【ほ・ しい】 (i-adj) - wanted; desirable
50. 来週 【らい・ しゅう】 - next week
51. 木曜日 【もく・ よう・ び】 - Thursday
52. ありがとう - thank you
53. 怠ける 【なま・ ける】 (ru-verb) - to neglect, to be lazy about
54. 来る 【く・ る】 (exception) - to come
55. そんな - that sort of
56. こと - event, matter

We learned quite a lot of things in this section. Let's try to put it all together by seeing how different kinds of conjugations are used in different combinations. This is of course by no means an exhaustive list but merely an illustration of how we can use what we learned in various combinations to create a lot of useful expressions.

Example 1

アリス： 加賀先生、ちょっと質問を聞いてもいいですか？

加賀先生： はい、いいですよ。

アリス： 「Hello」を日本語で何と言えがいいですか。

何と言え = quoted sub-clause + if conditional of 言う

加賀先生： そうね。大体、「こんにちは」と言うと思いますよ。ただし、書く時は「こんにちは」じゃなくて、「こんにちは」と書かなくてはなりません。

「と言うと思います」 = quoted sub-clause + quoted sub-clause

「じゃなくて」 = negative sequence of states

アリス： そうですか。他に何かいい表現はありますか。

加賀先生： これも覚えといてね。朝は、「おはよう」と言うの。でも、上の人には「おはようございます」と言ってください。

「覚えといて」 - 覚える + abbreviated form of ~ておく + casual ~てください with ください dropped.

アリス： はい、分かりました。間違えないようにします。いい勉強になりました！

Literal translation of Example 1

Alice: Kaga-sensei, is it ok to ask you a question? Kaga-sensei: Yes, it's ok. Alice: If you say what for "hello" in Japanese, is it ok? Kaga-sensei: Well, mostly, I think people say "konnichiwa". Only, when you write it, you must write "konnichiha" and not "konnichiwa". Alice: Is that so? Are there any other good expressions? Kaga-sensei: Please memorize this too (in preparation for the future). In the morning, everybody says, "ohayou". But, please say, "ohayou-gozaïmasu" to a higher person. Alice: Yes, I understood. I'll do in the manner of not making mistake. It became good study!

Interpretative translation of Example 1

Alice: Kaga-sensei, is it ok to ask you a question? Kaga-sensei: Sure. Alice: How do you say "Hello" in Japanese? Kaga-sensei: Well, most of the time, I think people say "konnichiwa". Only, when you write it, you must write "konnichiha" and not "konnichiwa". Alice: Is that so? Are there any other good expressions? Kaga-sensei: You should know this too. In the morning, everybody says, "ohayou". But, please say, "ohayou-gozaïmasu" to a higher person. Alice: Ok, I got it. I'll try not to make that mistake. That was very informative!

Example 2

洋介：お！アリスだ。あのね、質問を聞いてもいい？アリス：何？

洋介：ちょっと英語を教えてもらいたいんだけどさ、もし時間があれば、教えてくれない？「教えてもらいたい」= receiving favor + to want (たい)

アリス：え？英語を勉強するの？

洋介：うん、アメリカで留学してみたいなと思ってね。去年も行こうとしたけど、お金がなくて・・・「してみたいなと思って」= to try something out (～てみる) + want to (たい) + な sentence-ending particle + quoted subquote + te-form of 思う「行こうとした」= volitional of 行く + to attempt (とする)

アリス：そうなの？いいよ。いつ教えてほしいの？洋介：いつでもいいよ。アリス：じゃ、来週の木曜日からはどう？洋介：うん、いいよ。ありがとう！

アリス：勉強を怠けたり、来なかったり、しないでね。「怠けたり来なかったりしないで」= List of actions (～たりする) + negative request of する。

洋介：そんなことしないよ！

Literal translation of Example 2

Yousuke: Oh! It's Alice. Hey, is it ok to ask a question? Alice: What? Yousuke: I want to receive the favor of you teaching English and if, by any chance, you have time, will you give the favor of teaching? Alice: Huh? You are going to study English? Yousuke: Yeah, I was thinking that I want to try studying abroad in America. I tried to make motion toward going last year too but, without money... Alice: Is that so? It's good. When do you want me to teach you? Yousuke: Anytime is good.

Alice: Then what about from next week Thursday? Yousuke: Yeah, ok. Thanks! Alice: Don't do things like shirk on your studies or not come, ok? Yousuke: I won't do anything like that!

Interpretative translation of Example 2

Yousuke: Oh! It's Alice. Hey, can I ask you a question? Alice: What up? Yousuke: I want to learn English so if you have time, can you teach me? Alice: Huh? You're going to study English? Yousuke: Yeah, I was thinking about studying abroad in America. I tried going last year too but I didn't have the money. Alice: Really? No problem. When do you want me to teach you? Yousuke: Anytime is fine. Alice: What about from next week Thursday then? Yousuke: OK, thanks! Alice: You're not going to shirk on your studies or not come or anything right? Yousuke: I won't do anything like that!